



Failure in Startup Culture in Finland

Introducing The Failure Canva Tool

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ABSTRACT

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EMILIA LAAKSO & OSHADI MOHOTTIARACHCHI:
Failure in Startup Culture in Finland
Introducing The Failure Canva Tool

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This thesis was conducted for Tribe Tampere, our client that supports and connects the local startup community. It examines the meaning of failure in Finnish startup culture and introduces The Failure Canva Tool, a self-reflective tool that helps entrepreneurs turn failure into growth and learning. The purpose was to combine emotional reflection and strategic analysis into a practical tool that supports entrepreneurs in processing their experiences positively and constructively. The research followed a qualitative approach, including interviews with Finland-based startup founders and validation with five teampreneur cooperatives from Proakatemia at Tampere University of Applied Sciences. The thesis is grounded in entrepreneurial failure, mindset, and resilience. The findings show that entrepreneurs' emotions significantly influence their experiences and recovery from failure. These insights guided the redesign of The Failure Canva Tool to include emotional factors at the beginning and end, enabling users to analyse, learn, and identify ways to improve in the future. Validation suggests that the tool is effective, emotionally engaging, and user-friendly, helping users connect emotions with strategic thinking and decision-making. Future actions include creating a digital version, expanding testing with external entrepreneurs, and integrating the tool into entrepreneurial education to support open communication and emotional resilience in the startup environment.

Key words: Failure, Entrepreneurship, Startup Culture, Finland, Learning from Failure, Emotional Reflection, Resilience, Failure Canva Tool, Proakatemia, Entrepreneurial Mindset

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1 INTRODUCTION

Since the beginning of human life, failure has played a crucial role on how individual's grow and learn. No one enters the world with perfect knowledge or skills; instead, development is built through repeated mistakes and adjustments. As noted by the Child Mind Institute (2025), children must be allowed to fail naturally, from misspelling words to falling while learning to walk, because these small failures help them develop emotional resilience, tolerance for discomfort, and confidence in their own learning process. This early exposure to failure through trial-and-error lays the foundation for a lifelong ability to adapt and improve.

In our everyday lives, failure appears in many ways: relationships that don't work out, goals that aren't met, or habits that people struggle to build. Similarly, in professional and work life, people face setbacks, make wrong decisions, and encounter unexpected outcomes. Whether in personal or professional contexts, failure is not only common but also essential; it provides valuable lessons, forces adaptation, and ultimately contributes to improvement and innovation.

This same reality applies in entrepreneurship, and especially in the world of startups. Failure is not only common but also expected. Startups operate in environments marked by uncertainty, experimentation, and rapid iteration. In globally recognized startup ecosystems like Silicon Valley, failure is considered a valuable learning experience to be embraced, not avoided. The "fail fast, learn faster" mentality is widely adopted and even celebrated. (Koporcic et al., 2024)

The authors experienced failure also in addition to success, over the last three years at Proakatemia, through their journey of entrepreneurship. At first, our failures felt bitter and had difficulty accepting them. Over the last few years, through our experiences and learning from each other, the team began to realize that failure was not the end of our journey or the place to give up. Rather, it became a very important educational tool and is a critical part of been an entrepreneur.

Being members of a cooperative as part of our studies gave the opportunity to witness firsthand how failure happens and how much failure can contribute to learning. Firstly, naming our cooperative as KAAOS Projects Osk, which reflected the chaotic energy of our early days, which later on evolved into Novera Osk, which represented a new era and a stronger direction.

The journey to get to this point has not been without its own set of challenges, such as team dynamics, financial issues, and finding our market fit. Despite all of the obstacles that have been faced, those setbacks were not able to stop the team. Instead, the team learned to adapt, develop resilience, and view the mistakes made as a necessary part of growing and developing.

Failure has brought us as a team closer together. Through our experiences with failure, the members have developed the ability to be vulnerable, open more to emotions, and was willing to learn more about each other than before. For Novera, failure is not a setback; it is a space for people to grow, to transform, and to begin anew.

Entrepreneurial failure is naturally and developmentally present in all entrepreneurial contexts and contributes to both personal development and business development. Research studies have demonstrated that failures allow entrepreneurs to develop their ability to endure failure such as resilience to improve collaboration between team members and to create new opportunities (new strategic directions) for themselves and for their businesses (Cope, 2011; Shepherd, 2003). The experiences of our co-operative demonstrate how reflection upon difficult situations are important factors contributing to the learning and long-term development of entrepreneurs. For these reasons failure is a major theme of the thesis understanding failure as a process of development rather than as an endpoint.

This thesis has been developed together with Tribe Tampere, an organization that is at the heart of Tampere's startup and entrepreneurial culture. Tribe Tampere is a community-driven hub, founded in 2017, that brings together entrepreneurs, startup-teams, students and other ecosystem-enablers and provides a space for them to learn from each other, to experiment together and to share their experiences. The community's mission to create an environment that encourages openness, collaboration and resilience in the entrepreneurial spirit, and the subject of the thesis "failure in startup-culture in Finland" are therefore directly related to Tribe's mission. This cooperation allowed us to provide real added-value to the community through an investigation of how entrepreneurs perceive and learn from failures and how the results of such investigations can be used to enhance the individual founders and the broader startup-ecosystem.

In general, the purpose of this thesis is to analyse both the emotional and strategic aspects of failure in the Finnish startup-context, and to develop a practical reflective tool the Failure Canva that helps entrepreneurs transform what they perceive to be a failure into a meaningful learning experience. Theory was used as the foundation for developing the structure for the thesis and as we were researching in Finland, where the cultural aspect of the topic was particularly relevant. Research demonstrates that Finland has one of the highest fears of failure among the innovation driven economies in Europe, which has a negative impact on entrepreneurial activities because people fear to start new ventures or take entrepreneurial risks due to fear of failure (GEM, 2022). Thus, there is a need for tools that help founders to constructively process failures and reduce the emotional and psychological barriers to entrepreneurial behaviour.

The thesis will examine how entrepreneurs understand and experience failure and how they recover from setbacks, and the argument is that failure is not only an emotional hurdle but also a strategic necessity for entrepreneurship. By linking the ordinary emotional reactions of humans to the special pressure of the startup-world, the thesis underlines the significance of changing the view of failure as a source of knowledge, renewal and strength. As a key element of the thesis is the development of the Failure Canva Tool, to guide entrepreneurs to reflect emotionally, to analyse strategically and to act in the future, the thesis aims to assist a cultural and mental shift in Finland, that views failure as an indispensable, valuable and transformative element of entrepreneurial life.

The practical side of our thesis is implemented through qualitative interviews and through feedback from Proakatemia teampreneurs. Two out of four of our interviewees are former members of Tribe Tampere, which makes our research beneficial for our client, as their experiences reflect the needs and challenges of Tribe. Qualitative interviews were conducted with four startups from different industries, clothing, beauty & salon, restaurant & catering, and technology, to gather a wide range of perspectives and experiences with setbacks. These different industries allow the findings and our *Failure Canva tool* to be more applicable and useful across various sectors of the Finnish startup landscape.

The structure of the thesis is divided into three main parts: theoretical, tool creation, and testing.

The first part focuses on the theoretical framework, where the authors explore existing research and literature about failure, mindset, and the essential role failure plays in entrepreneurship. This thesis aims to show how failure creates value, encourages learning, and contributes to innovation. This theoretical foundation guided us to create the *Failure Canva Tool*. Understanding failure from a theoretical perspective helped to connect the concept to entrepreneurial development and the psychology of resilience.

The theoretical framework is divided into two chapters. The first, *Global Startup Failures*, presents a wide overview of failure in the global startup landscape, identifying key patterns, causes, and mindsets connected to resilience and learning. The second, *Startup Culture in Finland*, narrows the focus to the Finnish context, showing how cultural attitudes, fear of failure, and gender differences shape entrepreneurship locally. This structure allows the thesis to move smoothly from a global understanding to a national perspective, building a strong foundation for the practical part of the study.

The second part of the thesis is practice-based. In this phase, qualitative interviews were conducted with startup founders and entrepreneurs who openly shared their real-life experiences and insights related to failure. These interviews helped to bridge the gap between theory and practice, allowing to modify the Failure Canva tool based on genuine entrepreneurial perspectives. Through this stage, practical skills were developed, such as gaining meaningful insights from the interviews, managing time effectively with busy entrepreneurs, and having deep, reflective discussions about sensitive topics such as failure and emotions.

The final part of the thesis focuses on testing the *Failure Canva tool* with the help of five Proakatemia team companies. During this phase, the tool was tested with real project setbacks and collected constructive feedback from participants. Their comments helped to understand what aspects of the tool worked well and what could be improved for future developments. Reflecting on this feedback taught how constructive criticism can be approached with an open mind and use it as an opportunity to grow and improve the usability of our work.

2 GLOBAL STARTUP FAILURES

The term "failure" defines a situation when an expected goal or outcome is not achieved and causes emotional reactions of the sort of disappointment or frustration (Carver & Scheier, 1998). Failure is also a needed component of learning as it gives individuals useful information about their thought processes, behaviours and future plans (Dweck, 2006). However, in the case of entrepreneurship, failure has a much more complex role. The concept of failure doesn't refer to one mistake, but instead, to the end of a major endeavour of a business, project or entrepreneurial effort, caused by various types of failures including financial, strategic, operational, or emotional (Shepherd, 2003). Studies indicate that entrepreneurial failure is simultaneously disruptive and developmental. Although it can cause stress, grief or uncertainty, it allows for a greater opportunity for the entrepreneur to reflect on the experience, learn and strategically improve their venture (McMullen & Shepherd, 2006; Cope, 2011).

In the context of startups, understanding failure is particularly relevant. A startup is generally described as a new, innovation driven organization operating in an uncertain environment, attempting to create a scalable and repeatable business model (Blank & Dorf, 2012). Due to the nature of startups, they operate within a constantly changing and experimental environment and have very few resources, therefore, failure is common and expected in this type of environment. Therefore, how entrepreneurs perceive, manage and learn from failure, will ultimately determine their ability to be resilient, make decisions and succeed over the long-term. When failure is viewed as a learning mechanism and not an ultimate conclusion, it aligns with the entrepreneurial literature, which emphasizes the importance of setbacks to provide the opportunity for growth, adaptability and strategic development (Shepherd, 2003; Cope, 2011).

2.1 Startup success and failure rates: Patterns and causes

The nature of being a startup is extremely uncertain, highly competitive and it can be common for early-stage businesses to either be successful or unsuccessful.

Startup success typically means obtaining sustainable growth, market penetration and ultimately long-term profitability; whereas failure to achieve these objectives due to financial, strategic or market related shortcomings will result in the inability of a startup to continue operating (StartupTalky, 2023a). Current statistics show that approximately 90% of all startups fail. Within the first year, approximately 10% of startups close; and by the end of year 5, nearly 70% of startups have closed. Therefore, only an estimated 10% of all startups can successfully establish stable long-term growth (StartupTalky, 2023a). The number of failures by startups, clearly illustrates the large amount of pressure that founders endure during the initial phases of developing ventures.

Studies indicate that the primary reasons for the high rate of failure of startups include insufficient demand for the product/service; lack of capital for cash flow, lack of viable business model, incorrect pricing, inadequate team dynamics; and excessive competition (StartupTalky, 2023). The challenges listed above demonstrate why startup entrepreneurship is so dangerous and why founders continually must be flexible, learn from their mistakes, and develop their ability to be resilient in order to thrive in the current global economy.

There are various factors contributing to startup failure, but Startup Talky presents main key factors as follows: the most common cause is a lack of product-market fit (34%). This is followed by marketing problems (22%) and team-related challenges (18%). Financial difficulties account for 16%, while tech problems (6%), operational problems (2%), and legal problems (2%) occur less frequently (See Figure 1). These statistics show that failure usually comes from a mix of strategic and operational shortcomings, not just from a single isolated problem (StartupTalky, 2023).

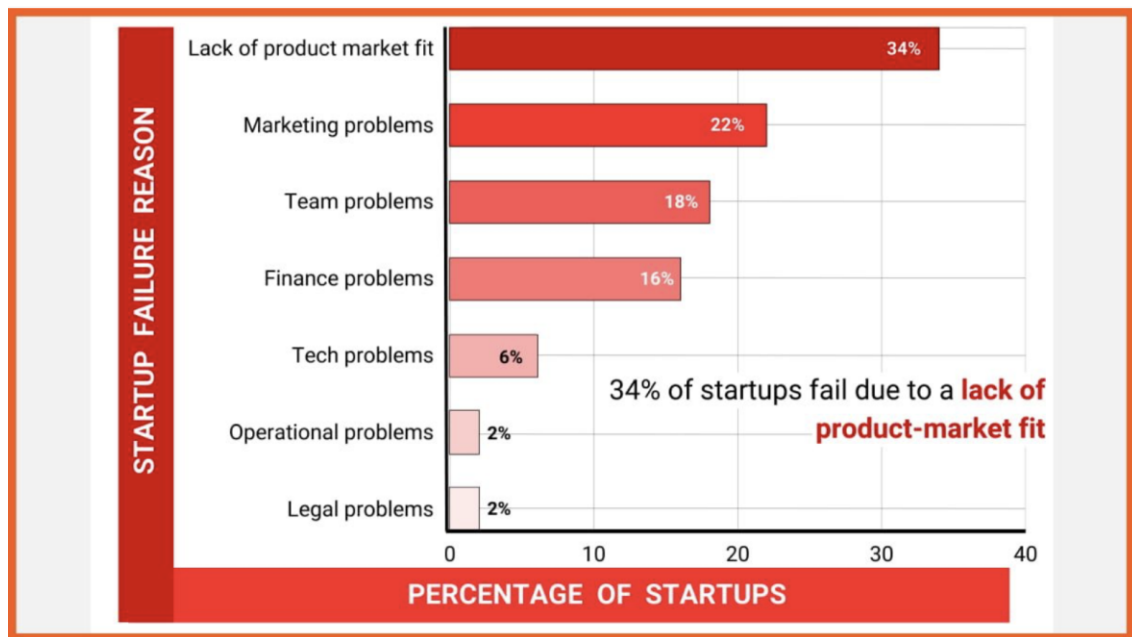


Figure 1. Why Do 90% of Startups Fail

Source: StartupTalky (2023).

Although these statistics may appear discouraging, they offer valuable insight into the entrepreneurial process. Failure should not be viewed as a dead end but as a natural and often eye-opening part of building a business and for the journey of entrepreneurship. Research shows that entrepreneurial failure can trigger deep learning, emotional recovery, and strategic re-evaluation, which strengthen resilience and future decision-making (Shepherd, 2003; Cope, 2011). For startup founders, developing resilience, adaptability, and reflective strategic thinking is crucial. By recognizing common challenges, entrepreneurs can more effectively tackle challenges and implement continuous, informed strategies that improve their chances of sustained success.

2.2 Mindset and attitude: The invisible drivers of success

Startups face more than just financial and structural difficulties; it's the mindset and attitude of the founders that play a crucial role in determining whether the venture thrives or fails. Reports increasingly show that how entrepreneurs handle setbacks can be just as important as their business model or funding. According to FasterCapital (2023), one key aspect of successful entrepreneurs is their ability to learn from failure. Instead of viewing setbacks as a negative endpoint, an entrepreneur should view them as valuable feedback, an opportunity to adjust their

approach and to rethink their strategies (Shepherd, 2003). This changes the perspective of failure from being a threat to becoming a powerful tool for acceptance, learning, and growth.

Failure is a part of the innovative process and that the entrepreneurial sectors build environments that foster risk-taking and experimentation (Drucker, 1985). However, the mindset and entrepreneurs' attitude towards failure is different in every cultural setting. In places like Silicon Valley, for example, failure is seen to represent courage and experience, as signs of someone moving forward. Entrepreneurs here are encouraged to fail fast and learn faster; this speeds their path to innovation and to find the right market fit (Maqubela, 2016).

Ultimately, failure is not the opposite of success but rather a step towards it. When embraced, failure produces resilience, strategic growth, and creativity. With a growth mindset and reducing negativity surrounding failure, especially in cultures where such choices are avoided due to the risk-taking involved, startup culture can open up better entrepreneurial possibilities, allowing for more innovative companies to grow (Shepherd, 2003).

2.3 Example: Netflix- Resilience in action

A real-life example related to mindset also the attitude about failure is the story of Netflix. The Netflix story highlights important facts about entrepreneurship: failure isn't the end, but an opportunity to grow. Statistics show that most startups don't succeed on their first try. Netflix's journey from various rejections to becoming a powerful leader in the entertainment industry demonstrates that resilience, adaptability, and learning from setbacks are essential for achieving success (Netflix, 2013).

Netflix shows how a flexible mindset and determination can turn early struggles into lasting successes. In 2000, Reed Hastings and Marc Randolph offered Blockbuster a \$50 million partnership, but it was quickly turned down. Blockbuster dismissed Netflix, then just a small DVD rental company, as unproven and not worth paying attention to (Business Insider, 2023). For many startups, this kind of rejection might have been the end, but for Netflix, it turned into a turning point where the company grew larger and more recognized by people.

Instead of giving up, Netflix shifted its approach. The company moved from mailing DVDs to leading the way in digital streaming and later started creating its own original shows. These bold moves did not just help Netflix continue, they changed the entertainment industry worldwide. A big part of this success came from a culture that encouraged trying new things, taking smart risks, and accepting failure as part of the process. Reed Hastings put it well “As an entrepreneur, you have to feel like you can jump out of an airplane because you’re confident that you’ll catch a bird flying by” (CNBC, 2024). This attitude allowed innovation to thrive and gave employees the freedom to explore new ideas without fear.

Netflix’s story reminds people that most startups don’t succeed immediately, but those that do tend to be led by individuals who view failure as a valuable learning experience rather than a defeat (StartupTalky, 2023; FasterCapital, 2023). Netflix’s rise from rejection to global success shows that being adaptable and willing to learn from failure are crucial to building a successful business.

As entrepreneurs, this shows how if failure is approached with a growth-driven mindset, it can become a starting point for long-term success. Reed Hastings and Marc Randolph’s experience shows that rejection and setbacks do not define a company’s destiny instead, they can change its strategy and strengthen its resilience. The Netflix case is relevant to this thesis because it represents its psychological and strategic layers of failure. Psychologically, the founders maintained positive and self-belief regardless of external rejection, which directly connects to the emotional aspect explored in this study, how entrepreneurs process failure internally and transform it into motivation. Strategically, Netflix used its failure as data by understanding what didn’t work, the company identified developing market opportunities, leading to its switch from DVD rentals to streaming and later original content creation (CNBC, 2024).

3 STARTUP CULTURE IN FINLAND

Finnish startup culture is best explained by its "ecosystem" approach to innovation, supporting entrepreneurs and startups through both public and private sector institutions, research organizations, and other collaborative partners. In the context of Finnish culture, Koskinen (2021) describes the evolution of startup culture in Finland as domesticating global entrepreneurial values into social norms in Finland, finding a balance between individualistic and proactive entrepreneurial behaviour and traditional social norms that emphasize collectivism and humility. Today, Finland's startup environment is characterized by intense collaboration, the use of advanced technology, and an emphasis on public support for innovation and entrepreneurship.

Cities such as Helsinki and Espoo function as innovation hubs that form dense ecosystems in which universities, corporate entities, and startups collaborate on developing innovative products and services, while cities such as Tampere and Turku continue to grow their own innovation networks (Enter Espoo, 2025; Business Finland, 2025). Examples of successful Finnish startup firms, including Supercell, Rovio, and Wolt, demonstrate how Finland's startup culture can foster the creation of internationally competitive startups in areas such as video games, health tech, and sustainable technologies (Work in Finland, 2025). Finland's startup culture represents the combination of a global entrepreneurial spirit with a local value system that emphasizes trust, collaboration, and a focus on long-term innovation and therefore provides a supportive environment for founders across various industries.

3.1 Introduction to Finnish culture and the startup landscape

Finnish culture is characterised by values such as trust, equality, modesty, resilience, and straightforward communication. Finnish entrepreneurship reflects these values of integrity, equity, restraint, and clarity in its collaboration processes, in the way they measure risk, and in the building of sustainable long term venture development. Studies have shown that while Finns adopt many of the

same entrepreneurial values found around the world, such as innovation, flexibility, and experimentation, the Finns adapt those values to fit the collaborative and non-hierarchical nature of the country's social culture (Koskinen, 2021).

The result is a highly innovative and collaborative ecosystem of startups in Finland that is supported successful Finnish companies mentioned before, Supercell, Wolt and Rovio, show how Finnish cultural values combined with strong ecosystem support create an environment where startups can develop, scale and compete internationally.

Finland is well known for its outstanding education system, high quality of life, and strong focus on technological innovation and advancement. These advantages, along with strong public institutions and an advanced digital framework, create a strong base for the country's growing startup scene. Finnish entrepreneurs are shaped by values such as modesty, determination, fairness, and a quiet confidence in collective progress (University of Oulu, 2023). These values shape how they approach innovation, take risks, and collaborate.

In the recent years, Finland has become more of an innovative country. Cities like Tampere, Oulu and Helsinki have become active cities for startup hubs. This is supported by strong public-sector support, a culture of shared knowledge, and foreign investments. According to ArcticStartup's survey about Finnish Startup Media survey (2024) says the startup community in Finland is unique because of its transparency, cooperation, and open-mindedness towards digitalization. The report clearly shows increasing interest from both investors abroad and in the country, mainly in technology, gaming, and sustainable fields.

According to recent studies conducted by the University of Oulu (2023) it has been found that the fear of failure is higher among women than men in Finland. Thus, this creates an imbalance in the number of female entrepreneurs who are involved in entrepreneurial activities. According to the University of Oulu (2023), because there are still traditional conservative views that exist in Finnish society and because societal expectations remain regarding the way women view risk-taking, especially in industries where men dominate, such as tech and growth startups, this limits the ability for women to participate in entrepreneurship.

Additionally, research also indicates that there are greater psychological barriers to women participating in entrepreneurship; including increased levels of self-doubt, decreased confidence when it comes to gaining access to capital, and less visibility of entrepreneurial women role models; therefore, the perception of risk associated with failure is both personally and socially higher for women, resulting in many women choosing not to pursue entrepreneurial opportunities even though they have the skills and desire to do so. The factors create an environment that contributes to the lower number of female-led startup companies in Finland and provide evidence that the fear of failure can limit women's entrepreneurial participation at a disproportionate rate compared to men. In addition, research conducted on a larger scale has demonstrated that fear of failure has a significant impact on an individual's entrepreneurial behaviour, particularly on women and youth (University of Oulu, 2023; GEM, 2022; Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2021).

In comparison to other startup environments such as Silicon Valley, which accepts failure as an important step toward achieving success; whereas, in Finland, there is still a large degree of social stigma associated with failure. In order for a more global and competitive startup mindset to be developed in Finland, the cultural barriers preventing this type of mindset need to be addressed.

3.2 GEM Comparison: Finland and European Nations

The Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM) is one of the most widely used international research programmes on entrepreneurship. Its purpose is to monitor and assesses the difference in entrepreneurial activity, attitudes, and conditions within countries, as well as provide reliable data to assist Governments and organizations to enhance their support of entrepreneurs (Global Entrepreneurship Monitor, 2022). The primary source of data for the GEM is the Adult Population Survey (APS), which measures the adult population's entrepreneurial intentions, levels of entrepreneurial activity and fear of failure; while the secondary source of data is the National Expert Survey (NES) where experts evaluate the level of support provided by a country's environment for the development of new ventures

(Bosma & Kelley, 2019). These two surveys collectively provide a broad perspective on a country's entrepreneurial landscape and enable comparative assessments between different countries (Acs et al., 2014).

Even though the findings of the University of Oulu report that Finland has developed into a more innovative economy in the world, in the 2021–2022 report of GEM for Finland was based on how entrepreneurial Finland is compared to the rest of Europe's innovation driven economies. The statistic from the 2021 data, Finland's level of entrepreneurial intention being very low, with only 12 percent of adult Finns saying they would be starting their own businesses in the next three years; this is significantly less than other European countries such as the Netherlands, which had approximately double that amount of respondents indicating they were considering starting a new business (GEM, 2022, p. 21) (See Figure 2). This shows that the entrepreneurial spirit in Finland is weaker than some other European nations.

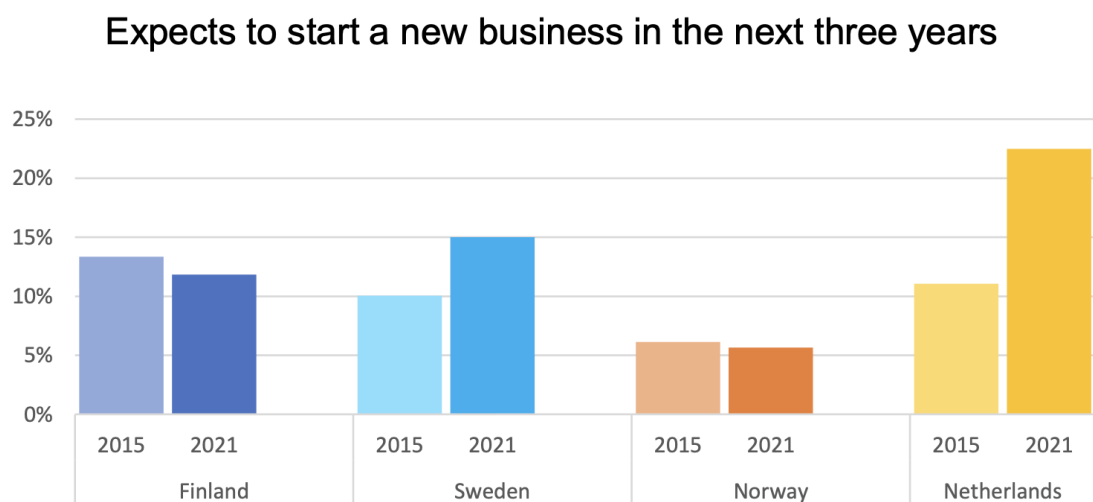


Figure 2. Expects to start a new business in the next three years

Source: Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (2022, p. 21)

A major reason for this caution is the fear of failure. The report shows that 49% of Finnish adults see fear of failure as a barrier to starting a business is one of the highest rates among innovation-driven economies in Europe (GEM, 2022, p. 27) (See Figure 3). In countries among Sweden, the Netherlands, and Norway, failure is often accepted as part of the process and even valued as a learning experience. In opposition to this, Finland's failure still carries a social stigma, making it harder for people to take the risk of starting their own business.

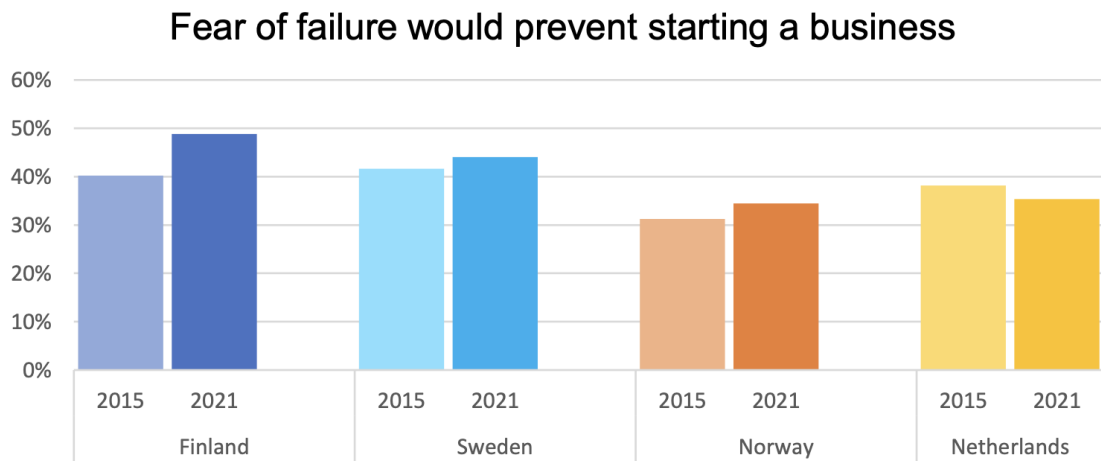


Figure 3. Fear of failure would prevent starting a business

Source: Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (2022, p. 23)

Even though entrepreneurship in Finland is mostly driven by opportunity rather than necessity, the Total Early-stage Entrepreneurial Activity (TEA) rate is still low at 5.3%, below the European average (GEM, 2022, p. 17). This stands out given Finland's strong education system and high digital readiness, both of which should ideally support more entrepreneurial activity.

These findings point to a key issue: despite Finland's strong foundations, psychological and cultural barriers significantly around risk and failure continue to hold back its entrepreneurial growth. Changing the way failure is viewed, from a personal fault to a useful step in the innovative journey, could be an important move toward building a more vibrant and resilient startup culture (GEM, 2022, p. 26-27).

3.3 Failure and Finnish startups: Gender, mindset, and opportunity

The GEM (Global Entrepreneurship Monitor) report of 2021–2022 indicates the persistence of existing gender differences in the field of entrepreneurship in Finland. In 2021, more than two men started a business for each woman engaged in this activity. This gap is wider than in many other innovation-driven European countries such as Sweden, Norway and Netherlands. (Global Entrepreneurship Monitor [GEM], 2022, p. 20).

The global gender gap in entrepreneurship is decreasing, but there still exists considerable differences in many countries, including Finland. Although Finnish

women have very high educational attainment and participate heavily in the labour force, the odds that a woman will be an entrepreneur are lower than for men; according to the GEM report, this gap in entrepreneurship rates among Finnish men and women can be attributed primarily to a difference in fear of failure and entrepreneurial self-efficacy between the genders. The gender comparison chart (p. 26-27) shows how fear of failure was cited as a barrier to starting or growing a business by 56 percent of female respondents and by 38 percent of male respondents (GEM 2022, pp. 26–27)

While significant structural barriers persist in the field, there are positive trends. Research shows that the number of visible, successful female founders in Finland is on the rise particularly in areas like gaming, sustainable innovation and digital services (GEM, 2022). When women gain support, mentorship, and connections to other networks, their propensity for creating new ventures rises dramatically; international comparative data indicate that countries with many more examples of female entrepreneurs as Sweden and Estonia, tend to have significantly higher levels of female entrepreneurship, suggesting cultural norms can strongly shape outcomes (Startup Genome, 2023). According to the University of Oulu report (2023), there are a few things that could be done to address the gender imbalance in entrepreneurship in Finland: showcase more successful female leaders; expand the current number of mentorship programs; and create additional opportunities for funding specifically for women.

These strategies help reframe what it means to fail by shifting perceptions of failure from a personal failing to an important part of the entrepreneurial learning process. Therefore, Finland needs a broader cultural transformation: In order to create a culture of inclusive entrepreneurship, failure should be viewed as a strength rather than a weakness and an essential component of driving innovation and entrepreneurial resilience. By making this cultural transformation, Finland will be able to close the gap with more established startup ecosystems and provide underrepresented groups such as women and young entrepreneurs with the courage to be bolder and take greater risks in developing their own businesses.

Even though Finland benefits from strong education, high digital readiness, and extensive public investment in innovation, deep-rooted social and psychological barriers continue to slow entrepreneurial activity. The GEM (2022) report clearly shows that fear of failure, limited diversity, and persistent gender gaps remain major hurdles in fully unlocking Finland's entrepreneurial potential (GEM, 2022; University of Oulu, 2023; Startup Genome, 2023; Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2021).

3.4 Finnish startup mindset

As discovered by far, Finland's entrepreneurial scene has traditionally been shaped by being cautious and having a strong focus on perfection, which often leads to avoiding risks. Under these circumstances, failure hasn't been seen as a natural part of starting a business but rather as a personal flaw. This mindset has held back many potential entrepreneurs, especially young people and women, as mentioned in the previous chapter. However, recent years suggest that this reserved culture is gradually evolving. While earlier studies described an ecosystem controlled by fear of failure and low entrepreneurial intention, newer insights reveal a more open and reflective attitude emerging among Finnish founders.

A recent report on "the 2025 Finnish Startup Media Survey" by ArcticStartup found that an increasing number of (more than 60%) of Finnish startup founders believe they can learn from their failures, rather than view them as embarrassing failures. This has been a significant change from past Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM) reports (from 2021-2022), which showed fear of failure was one of the most common obstacles to becoming entrepreneurs in Finland. In addition, the 2025 report shows that there is an increasing emphasis in the Finnish startup community to appreciate entrepreneurship as a process involving trial-and-error and learning through failure and experience, and as such, to cultivate qualities that successful entrepreneurs should have (such as being resilient, adaptable and always seeking to learn).

These trends support broader research indicating that modern startup ecosystems encourage experimentation and iterative learning, and support environments help to diminish the emotional and psychological costs of failure (Cope, 2011; Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2021; Shepherd et al., 2016). The overall impression is that the culture is beginning to change in terms of how it views failure as part of an entrepreneurial development process (University of Oulu, 2023; ArcticStartup, 2024; GEM, 2022; Cope, 2011; Shepherd et al., 2016)

According to Pauliina Björk from the University of Oulu (2023), fear of failure continues to be a persistent issue in Finland and should be discussed more openly within the startup community. Björk's work highlights that many Finnish entrepreneurs are beginning to view failure as a "strategic experience" a necessary step that contributes to growth, innovation, and long-term success. (University of Oulu, 2023).

To fully tap into its entrepreneurial potential in the future, Finland needs to keep building a startup culture that removes the stigma around failure, encourages trying new things, and gives entrepreneurs support on both a personal and institutional level (consulting, providing tools & materials). This includes creating spaces where people feel safe to take risks, fail, learn, and try again without worrying about social or professional fallout. Accepting failure as part of learning will not only boost innovation but also help close gender gaps and bring more people into the startup ecosystem, enabling Finland's real ability to innovate and lead worldwide. The data from the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM) indicates that the level of fear of failure in Finland has been rising, with fear of failure reported at about 45% in 2015 and increasing to approximately 49% in 2021.

In addition, females consistently report higher fear of failure (56%) compared to males (38%). This suggests that while there has been some progress, it remains slow and unequal; reducing the stigma around failure would increase innovation, help close gender gaps, and encourage greater diversity in the startup ecosystem (GEM 2022, pp. 26–28).

4 USAGE OF DEVELOPMENT FRAMEWORK AND TOOLS

Although mindset plays an important role in entrepreneurship, applying strategic frameworks and practical tools is equally essential. Strategic frameworks refer to structured models such as the Business Model Canvas, Lean Startup methodology, or early-stage development models that help entrepreneurs understand how different parts of a business interact and how decisions should be approached (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010; Ries, 2011). Practical tools, on the other hand, are concrete methods or visual templates such as canvases, checklists, experiment boards, or SWOT analysis that founders use to analyse ideas, test assumptions, and track progress (Gürel & Tat, 2017). Together, these frameworks and tools give entrepreneurs a systematic way to monitor development, reflect on outcomes, and make informed decisions in changing environments.

The utilization of strategic frameworks also provides startups with the opportunity to transform experience into actionable knowledge, identify what is or isn't working, and adaptively modify their business model to support sustainable growth (European Investment Bank, 2020). Their purpose is to reduce uncertainty, support learning, and guide founders toward more resilient and evidence-based business development.

According to the European Investment Bank report (2020), many European startups struggle not because of a lack of innovation but due to the absence of systematic frameworks that support their growth. The report emphasizes that structured approaches, mentoring, and business development tools are necessary for startups to connect the gap between early-stage innovation and long-term sustainability. In the European context, frameworks such as incubator programs, early-stage models and Lean Startup frameworks provide the foundation for building strategic abilities and resilience. Evidence from Finnish research supports this argument.

Research conducted on the Lean Startup framework in Finnish startup enterprises demonstrates that when entrepreneurs use structured frameworks such as experimentation cycles, hypothesis testing, and customer feedback loops, they become better prepared to handle uncertainty and limited resources (Hytti et al., 2023).

support team communication in developing and refining business ideas with less time spent (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010).

This approach allows an entrepreneur to see their business holistically and from the inside out. However, there are some disadvantages to using the Business Model Canvas; it can be too broad or abstract, lacking specific detail regarding financial planning or operational process development, and it may oversimplify very complex business systems. Also, it does not provide guidance for innovating or adapting to rapidly changing business environments (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010).

4.2 Value Proposition canvas (VPC)

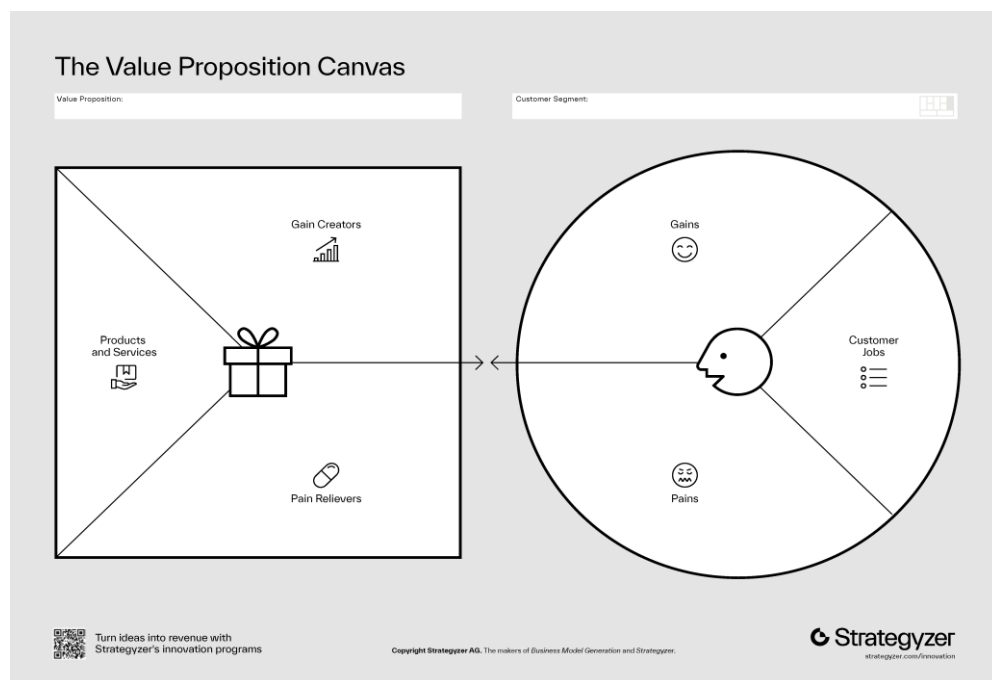


Figure 5. Value Proposition Canvas

Source: Strategyzer (n.d.).

The Value Proposition Canvas was created by Alexander Osterwalder to expand upon the Business Model Canvas and support entrepreneurs in gaining a deeper understanding of their clients' needs, so they may develop products or services that will better meet those needs (Osterwalder et al., 2014). The goal of the Value Proposition Canvas is to provide a visual representation of the customer's jobs,

pain points, and gains on one side, and the company's product offerings, pain point reducers and gain creators on the other, which provides clarity on whether a product or service solution addresses actual customer problems (Osterwalder et al., 2014). One of the main strengths of the Value Proposition Canvas is its ability to enhance customer knowledge and decrease assumptions for teams when designing solutions that are best suited to the market. It also promotes team-based dialogue and encourages user-centric thinking (Osterwalder et al., 2014).

However, the Value Proposition Canvas does have weaknesses: it can minimize the complexity of customer behaviour, and it requires high-quality customer data if the data is poor, the Value Proposition Canvas becomes less valuable. Additionally, this tool only considers the development of value for the client, not the overall business strategy (competition) or the long-term viability of the business (Osterwalder et al., 2014)

4.3 SWOT analysis

SWOT ANALYSIS TEMPLATE	
STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS

WordStream
by LOCALIQ

Figure 6. SWOT analysis

Source: WordStream (n.d.).

SWOT analysis was first created by Albert Humphrey in the 1960s for use as an organizational strategic planning tool to assist businesses with evaluating their internal strengths and weaknesses, as well as external opportunities and threats (Humphrey, 2005). A SWOT analysis is intended to create a clear picture of the factors that could support or impede a company's success, thereby allowing for improved decision-making and strategy development (Humphrey, 2005). The primary advantage of using a SWOT analysis is its ease of application and the ability to apply the tool across organizations of all sizes. Although there are many advantages of using SWOT analysis, there are also several disadvantages.

SWOT analyses rely heavily on opinion rather than fact and do not explain the methods used to identify the listed strengths, weaknesses, opportunities or threats (Gürel & Tat, 2017). Furthermore, SWOT analyses often oversimplify complex business environments and do not indicate which factors are the most important (Gürel & Tat, 2017).

4.4 Fail Canvas

Fail Canvas

Problem Reasons your customers won't care or are incentivised not to be interested in the problems you say they have.	Solution Technical & non-technical reasons your particular solution to the problems you say customers have won't work.	Unique Value Proposition Callout key failure points on Gains, Pains and Customer Jobs using a skeptical, slightly pessimistic lens.	Unfair Advantage Explain why all the unique advantages you claim are not unique, and are actually commodities or easily reproduced.	Customer Segments Go through the channels you've listed for how you plan to reach customers and explain how each of these channels won't work.
	Key Metrics Highlight two metrics related failure points		Channels Go through the channels you've listed for how you plan to reach customers and explain how each of these channels won't work.	
Cost Structure What areas of cost do you need to manage most closely? What could sink the ship?			Revenue Streams Address key challenges with your pricing or the revenue line of your unit economics. Play devil's advocate and look at why you won't be able to justify the price you're asking for your product.	

Created 2019 by Scott Middleton, Terem Technologies

Figure 7. Fail canvas

Source: Terem Technologies (n.d.).

The Fail Canvas was developed by Scott Middleton at Terem Technologies in 2019 as a way for startups to test whether their business model would actually work, rather than just assuming it will (Middleton, 2019). Similar in structure to the Business Model Canvas, each section of the Fail Canvas is evaluated negatively; rather than asking how the problem, solution, channel or revenue stream will function, you ask why it will fail, what assumptions are likely to be incorrect and what could cause costs and/or metrics to damage your business (Middleton, 2019). The most valuable aspect of using the Fail Canvas is that it compels founders to evaluate their own ideas, identify risks that may have been overlooked and develop contingency plans to mitigate these risks before investing too much time or money (Middleton, 2019).

In addition, the Fail Canvas can support more honest conversations among teams, particularly in highly optimistic startup cultures. The Fail Canvas also has drawbacks: while a balanced approach can help you identify potential pitfalls, focusing too much on negative aspects may reduce creativity and discourage innovation. Like all canvases, the Fail Canvas provides a general overview of where potential problems exist but does not give a complete picture of the financial or operational aspects of the business, nor does it offer specific solutions to the identified problems (Middleton, 2019).

5 INTRODUCING THE FAILURE CANVA TOOL

The Failure Canva Tool was created to address a clear gap in the existing entrepreneurial tools and frameworks: such as frameworks like the Business Model Canvas and Value Proposition Canvas help founders design and analyse their business ideas, and tools for example SWOT analysis or the Fail Canvas support risk-thinking, none of them fully integrate the emotional, reflective, and strategic sides of entrepreneurial failure. The inspiration for the Failure Canva Tool came from combining the structured clarity of the Business Model Canvas, the customer-insight logic of the Value Proposition Canvas, the diagnostic approach of SWOT analysis and the risk-focused perspective of the Fail Canvas. However, instead of focusing solely on business components or negative scenario testing, the Failure Canva Tool integrates emotional reflection with practical learning from experienced setbacks which will be explained more in 5.1.

This can be more suitable for founders navigating the personal, often sensitive nature of failure, especially in the Finnish startup context where openly discussing setbacks can be challenging. The GEM Finnish National Report supports this, noting that Finland scores low on cultural and social norms that encourage entrepreneurial risk-taking, and that the fear of failure among potential entrepreneurs has increased in recent years, remaining higher than in many comparison countries. These cultural barriers make it difficult for founders to openly process setbacks, which further emphasises the need for tools that help entrepreneurs transform failure into insight, resilience and actionable development steps (GEM, 2022, pp. 19–20, 26).

5.1 What is The Failure Canva Tool

This tool is a canvas-based framework specifically developed for failure analysis and reflective learning. In comparison to frameworks such as the Fail Canvas (Middleton 2019), which helps founders to predict potential causes of future product or business failures, The Failure Canva tool adopts a reflective approach, meaning taking time to think carefully about experiences, analyse what happened, and understand *why* it happened so that you can learn and improve in the future (Shepherd, 2003; Cope, 2011). It guides entrepreneurs in an organized

way, examining actual failures they have experienced. By guiding entrepreneurs to break down difficult situations into individual segments, the framework gathers both strategic and emotional aspects of failure. This process could turn often overwhelming experiences into structured, transparent, and actionable insights.

5.2 Purpose and the uniqueness of the tool

Every entrepreneurial tool is created with its own specific purpose and unique value. The purpose for a tool refers to tools that are designed to support different stages of business development, and each tool has both a purpose refers to why it was created and what problem it helps entrepreneurs solve (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010) and a uniqueness meaning a specific value or perspective it brings that other tools do not offer (Ghezzi & Cavallo, 2020). For example, as mentioned before in 4.1–4.5, some tools help with planning (Business Model Canvas), others with understanding customers (Value Proposition Canvas), others with identifying risks (SWOT, Fail Canvas), and some with learning from setbacks (Failure Canva Tool). Tools give structure to complex processes, enabling entrepreneurs to make informed decisions, organize information, and reduce uncertainty.

This Failure Canva Tool has been designed specifically for combining mindset development and strategy development. Mindset development refers to the process of shaping and strengthening the attitudes, beliefs and ways of thinking that influence how a person approaches challenges, learning and decision-making (Dweck, 2006). Strategy development refers to the structured process of defining a clear direction, making decisions about how to allocate resources, and planning how to achieve long-term goals. It involves analysing the environment, identifying opportunities and risks, and choosing the best actions to remain competitive and sustainable. (Porter, 1996). Both developments could enable fellow founders to process failure, which is not just related to practical challenges but also growth opportunities.

By taking founders through a process of emotional rational leaps and logical understanding, this tool can assist in revealing the reasons behind failure and the implications it brings, the consequences of repeated patterns in decision making and how these insights can be translated into concrete, actionable improvements.

This mindset and strategy development approach can fill the key gap in existing entrepreneurial tools, which often emphasize either strategic design or mindset development, but rarely both. Through its visual and step-by-step format, the Failure Canva simplifies the process of transforming experiences of failure into actionable learning outcomes. It supports entrepreneurs in building resilience, adaptability, and self-awareness, while validating continuous strategic development, turning failure into an ongoing and essential part of the entrepreneurial journey (Middleton, 2019, Shepherd)

The first unique feature is that it positions failure as a constructive learning opportunity, encouraging entrepreneurs to engage with setbacks instead of avoiding or minimising them. Unlike traditional tools such as the Business Model Canvas (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010), the Value Proposition Canvas, or SWOT analysis, which primarily focus on planning, optimisation, and reducing risks, The Failure Canva centres failure as a valuable source of insight. This approach aligns with research showing that learning from failure enhances entrepreneurial resilience, adaptability, and long-term growth (Shepherd, 2003; Cope, 2011; Amankwah-Amoah, 2021).

The second uniqueness of the tool is the emotional impact of failure. Historically, failure was viewed negatively by Finns, and thus, many entrepreneurs tried to avoid discussing their setbacks publicly and focused on finding rational solutions to problems as opposed to taking the time to emotionally process those problems (GEM Finland Report, 2022; University of Oulu, 2023). Often, entrepreneurs fail to gain all that they could from experience due to not taking the opportunity to process it emotionally. Emotions can strongly affect how an individual perceives and recovers from failure. For example, as explained by Shepherd (2003), entrepreneurs who acknowledge and work through the emotions associated with failure (e.g., disappointment, frustration, etc.) will be able to use failure as an opportunity to grow personally and professionally. Adult psychology and trauma research states that emotional awareness and the ability to recover from adversity are central to resilience (Bonanno, 2004). As summarised by the Child Mind Institute (2025), these skills support individuals in continuing and adapting after setbacks.

Strategic structure which refers to the organised arrangement of processes, activities and decision-making pathways that support an organisation's strategy. It describes how a company is designed to implement its long-term goals, including how responsibilities are divided, how information flows, and how resources are allocated. A strong strategic structure ensures that the organisation's strategic choices are supported by appropriate systems, processes, and coordination mechanisms (Chandler, 1962; Porter, 1996).

Psychological reflection refers to the internal process of examining one's thoughts, emotions, reactions, and behaviours to gain deeper understanding and learning. In entrepreneurship, psychological reflection helps individuals interpret their experiences including failure by identifying emotional responses, cognitive patterns, and personal assumptions. This reflective processing enhances self-awareness, learning, and future decision-making (Schön, 1983; Shepherd, 2003; Cope, 2011).

By combining both strategic structure and psychological reflection in the tool bridges the critical and emotional side of entrepreneurship and offers entrepreneurs an opportunity to consider that failure is not just the end point but a motivator for further growth through learning and renewal. This perspective is particularly valuable in relation to countries such as Finland, where fear of failure remains a cultural barrier to entrepreneurship (University of Oulu, Kerttu Saalasti Institute, 2023). The Failure Canva provides a safe, structured way to confront that fear by helping entrepreneurs embrace failure as a positive, necessary and process where you move forward that strengthens both individual mindset and business capability.

5.3 Visual design of the tool

The visual design of a tool refers to how the information, components and structure of the tool are organised, presented and displayed in a clear and user-friendly manner. Effective visual design helps users understand complex information quickly by using layout, shapes, colours and spatial organisation to guide attention and support problem-solving. Good visual design enhances usability, re-

duces cognitive load, and improves the user's ability to interpret relationships between different elements within the tool (Tufte, 1990; Norman, 2013). In entrepreneurial frameworks, strong visual design is crucial because it allows founders to grasp complex business concepts at a glance, facilitates team communication, and supports collaborative decision-making (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010).

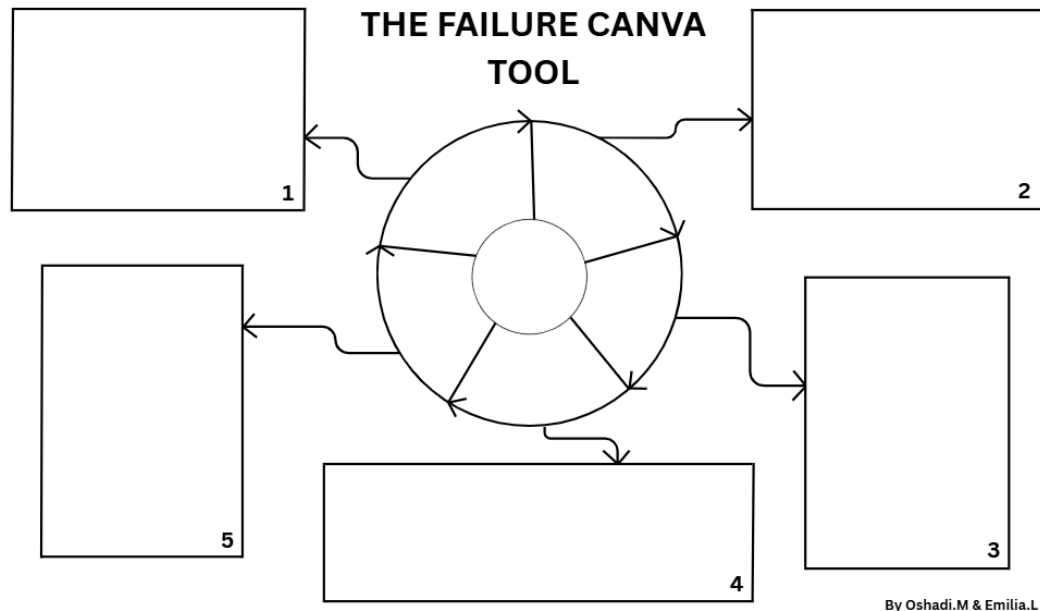


Figure 8. Visual Structure of the Failure Canva Tool

As visualized in the Figure 8, the stages of The Failure Canva Tool create an ongoing circular process that represent the natural lifecycle of entrepreneurship, an ongoing cycle of experimentation, reflection, learning, and transformation (Kolb, 1984; Cope, 2011; Shepherd, 2003). The Failure Canva is purposely designed as a circular shape because failure and growth are not a singular experience, but it is a continuous and ongoing (Kolb, 1984). The circular shape represents balance and continuous steps to show that each ending can become a new beginning. The arrows connecting each section symbolize growth and transformation, reminding entrepreneurs that failure is not an endpoint but a transition that steps towards improvement (Senge, 1990). This development visually expresses that reflection must always connect to action, ensuring that each failure becomes a step forward rather than a pause (Kolb, 1984).

The simplicity of the tool is one of its strongest features. It does not need any special training or facilitation to use effectively. The clear and simple structure

allows users to engage with it independently or collaboratively, making it practical for both individual reflection and group reflection/dialogue (Norman, 2013; Tufte, 1990). Simplifying the process helps users not overthink and get stuck in one place, instead it allows them to move smoothly from one stage to another (Osterwalder & Pigneur, 2010).

5.4 Segments of the tool

The Failure Canva incorporates elements of both current and past entrepreneurial and reflective tools, especially the Fail Canvas (Terem Tech, n.d.) and the Motorola Reflection Method (Motorola University, 1995; Proakatemia, 2024). Each element of the Failure Canva was carefully adapted to provide entrepreneurs with a systematic process that will lead from a focus on failure to a focus on learning, emotion, and to action. The Failure Canva provides a framework for reflection that includes both an analytical and emotional perspective.

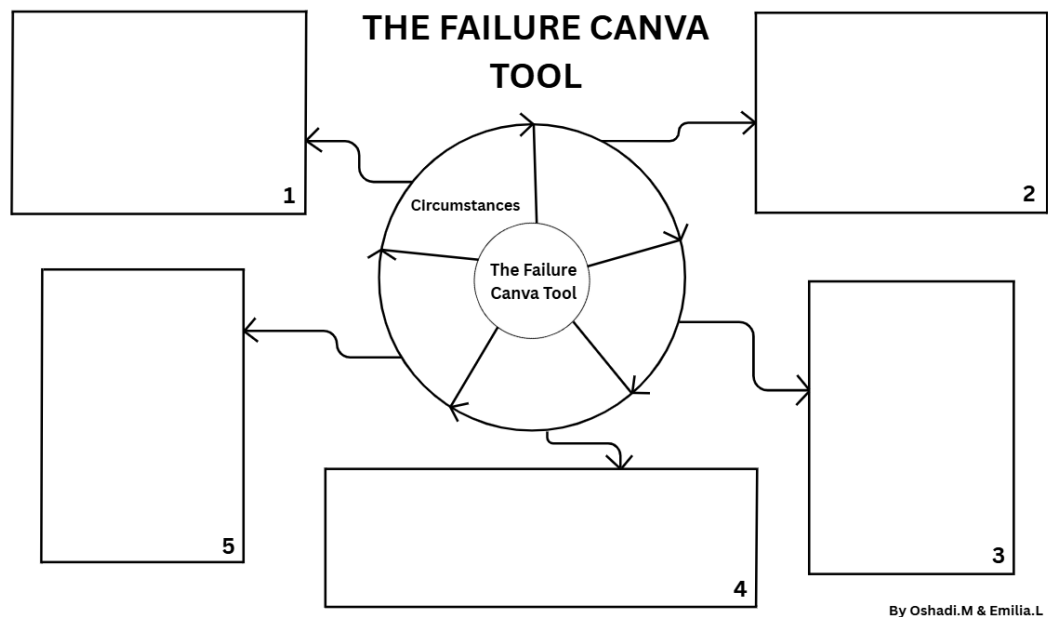


Figure 9. Showing Circumstances of the Failure Canva Tool

The figure 9 is the first stage of the Failure Canva tool is Circumstances, which is developed from the "Problem" section of the Fail Canvas (Terem Tech, n.d.), which defines the particular event, project, or decision that resulted in the failure. This step motivates entrepreneurs to look at the situation objectively and describe what happened without feeling judgmental or emotional discomfort.

By describing the steps and the context, the entrepreneurs have a better idea of what happened rather than depending on assumptions or memories that are caused by stress or disappointment. This allows reflection to begin from a place of clear understanding rather than confusion. The guiding question for this stage, such as *“What was the original goal or expectation vs how it ended up happening?”*, connects entrepreneurs with their actual outcomes with the actual results, creates a foundation for honest evaluation and future learning.

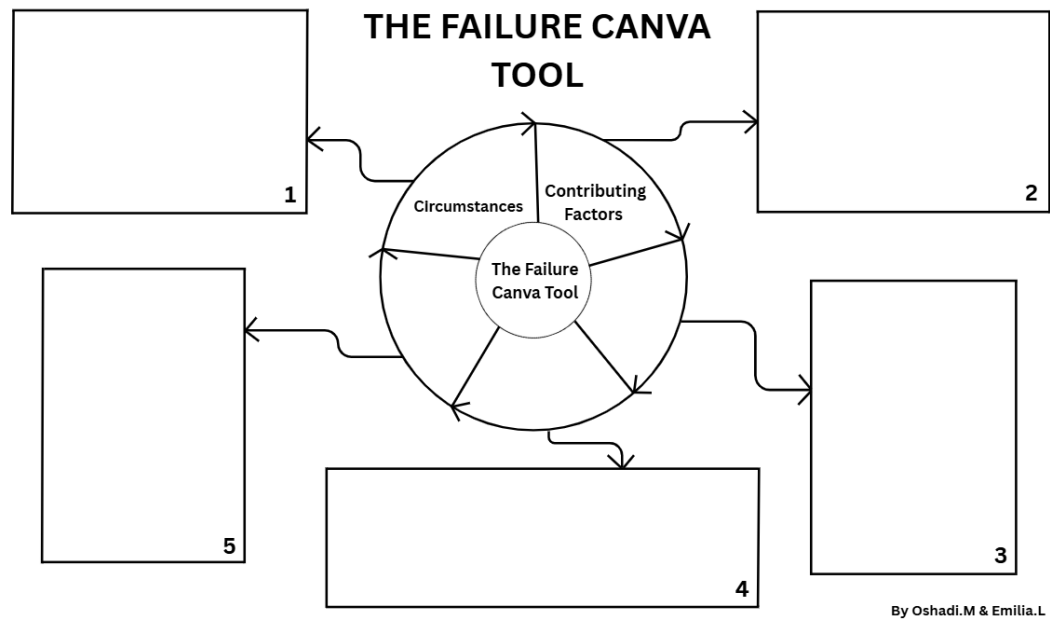


Figure 10. Showing Contributing Factors of the Failure Canva Tool

As visible in the figure 10 the second stage of the Failure Canva Tool is Contributing Factors, it was developed from the "Key Metrics" section of the Fail Canvas (Terem Tech, n.d.). The second stage of the Failure Canva is to identify and document the causes (both internal and external) that contributed to the result. Internal factors meaning the way a team makes decisions, the mindset of leadership, etc., these might contribute to failure just like external factors for example, market shifts, competition, funding, etc.). This broader perspective allows entrepreneurs to better understand not only what failed, but also why it happened, combining strategic and human views.

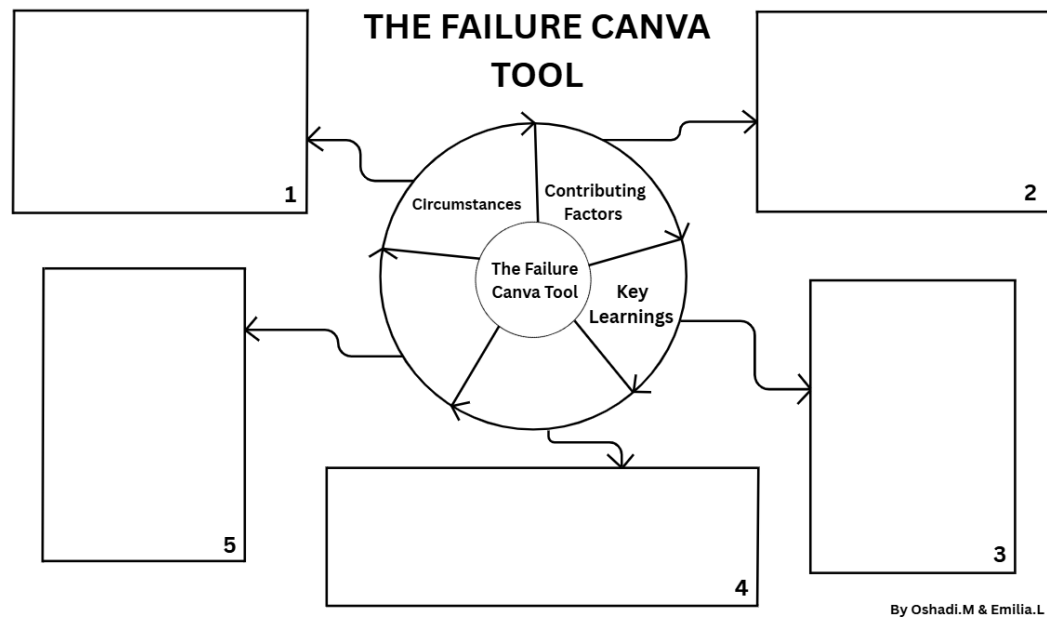


Figure 11. Showing Key Learnings of the Failure Canva Tool

The third stage of the Failure Canva is Key Learnings (Figure 11). This stage is created using the third question of the Motorola Reflection Method: "What did I learn?" (Motorola University, 1995; Proakatemia, 2024). This question provides entrepreneurs with an opportunity to reflect on the personal and professional development that has occurred since the failure. It creates space for entrepreneurs to identify the insights, discoveries, or increased understandings gained from the experience. This stage transforms the failure into a lesson that helps entrepreneurs realize what the failure teaches them about their behaviour, their work, and/or how they make decisions. As emphasized by Shepherd et al. (2016), the learning process is necessary to transform failures into sources of resilience and areas of improvement.

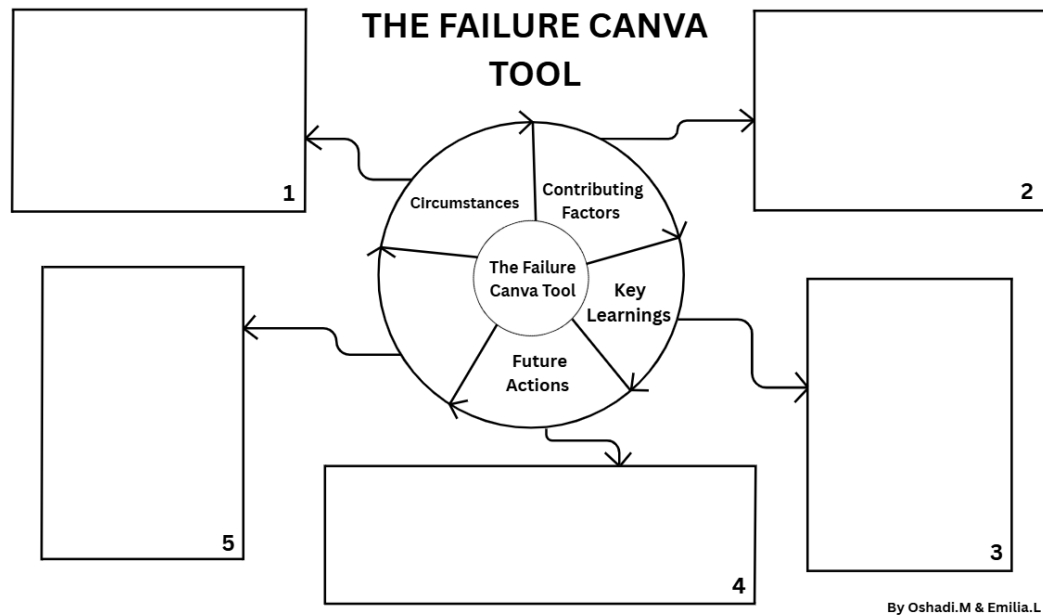


Figure 12. Showing Future Actions of the Failure Canva Tool

The fourth stage of the Failure Canva, is the Future Actions (figure 12), is created from the last question of the Motorola Reflection Method: "What am I taking into practice?" (Proakatemia, 2024). This stage connects the reflection process to actions by providing entrepreneurs with an opportunity to apply their insight into concrete actions. Examples of future actions could be changing the way a team communicates, refocusing on a strategy, or testing a new approach. The purpose of this stage is to ensure that reflection results in progress is necessary to create awareness into action and continued growth.

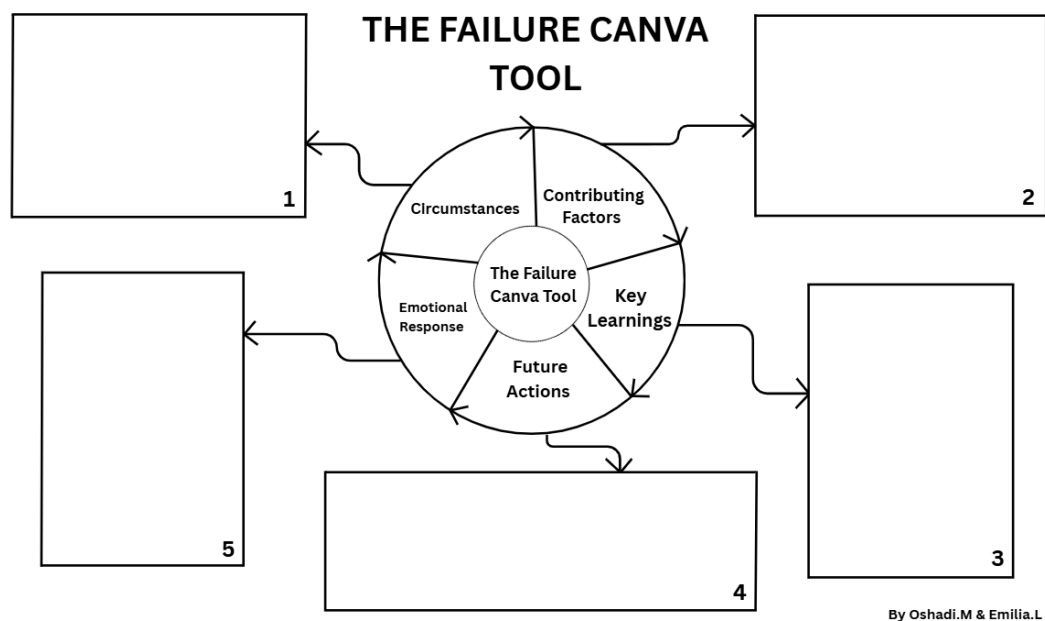


Figure 13. Showing Emotional Response of the Failure Canva Tool

The fifth and final stage of the Failure Canva, Emotional Response, which is visualized in Figure 13, is representing the uniqueness aspect of the Failure Canva mentioned before in 5.2. Unlike the Fail Canvas or the Motorola Method, the Emotional Response function was added to the Failure Canva to assist entrepreneurs in acknowledging and processing the emotional responses associated with failure. Recognizing emotions such as disappointment, frustration, and relief are all critical parts of recovering and developing self-awareness.

These elements are equally placed within the circle to show that no stage overpowers another. This reflects experiential learning theory, which emphasises that effective learning happens when cognitive, emotional and behavioural processes hold equal importance in a balanced cycle of reflection and action (Kolb, 1984). Each element helps to understand failure by combining emotional processing, analytical thinking, and rethinking strategies, a combination shown by entrepreneurship research to be essential for transforming failure into meaningful learning and improved future decision-making (Shepherd, 2003; Cope, 2011).

5.5 The question creation for each segment of Tool

The failure canvas tool's first structure has been developed based on the section 5.3 in a circular format, where there are simple arrows linking the core to the external questions, signifying the cyclical nature of the reflection and actions. The arrows link each of the core components: Circumstances, Contributing Factors, Key Learnings, Future Actions, and Emotional Response to the respective questions surrounding the circle (Section 5.4). With a simple and easy-to-follow design, users will be able to navigate the steps of the process seamlessly without being overwhelmed or having to over analyse the next step.

The Failure Canva Tool's five stages were based on the theoretical concepts that were described throughout the thesis as well as the following reflective methods that were taken from the Fail Canvas (Terem Tech, n.d.) and the Motorola Reflection Method (Motorola University, 1995; Proakatemia, 2024) as mentioned in 5.4. The questions that are used in the tool were created with the intention of guiding the user through a step-by-step process of reflection for each stage.

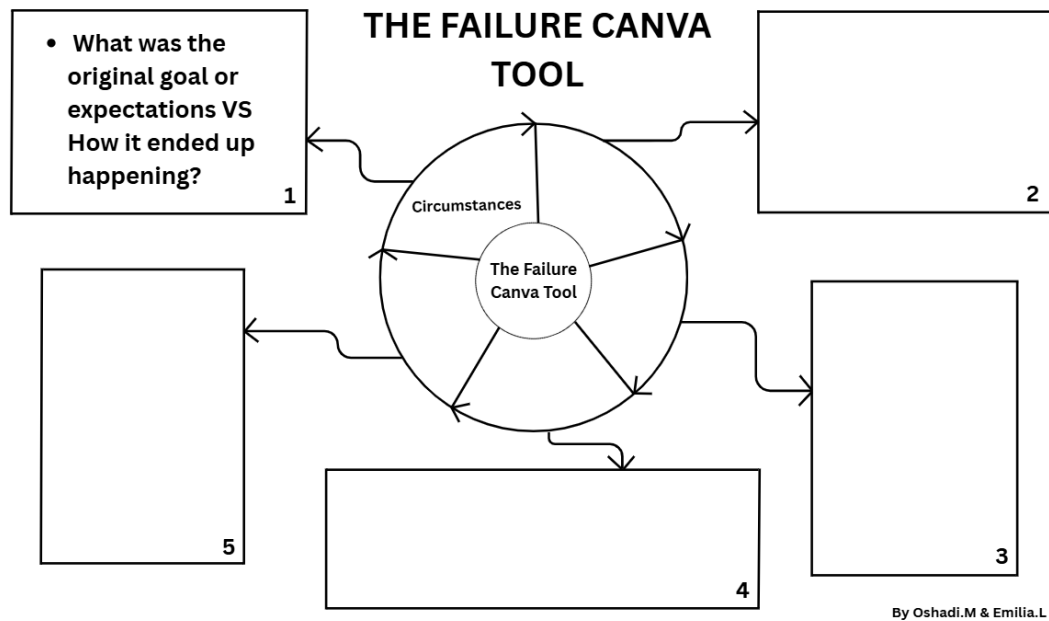


Figure 14. Defining Circumstance in the Failure Canva Tool

The first stage, Circumstances, helps users define what occurred in the objective circumstance. This stage is guided by the questions “*What was the original goal or expectation vs how it ended up happening?*” to determine the gap between the user's expected outcome and the final outcome (See Figure 14). This creates a factual foundation of the circumstances in which the outcomes were realized.

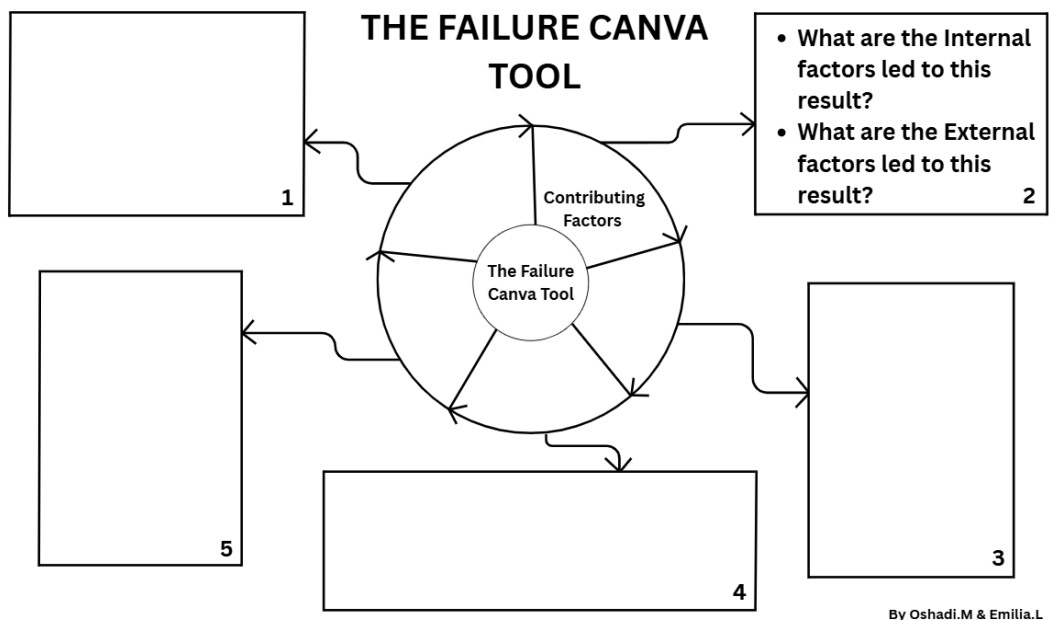


Figure 15. Defining Contributing Factors in the Failure Canva Tool

Contributing Factors, is the second phase of the process utilizing the "Key Metrics" section of the Fail Canvas. The purpose of Contributing Factors is to identify the causes of the outcomes with the use of two specific questions: "What are the internal factors contributing to this outcome?" and "What are the external factors contributing to this outcome?" (See Figure 15). Identifying internal (decision making; mindset) vs. external (market conditions; funding) contributing factors assists the user in understanding both their own role in the failure and the role of external events.

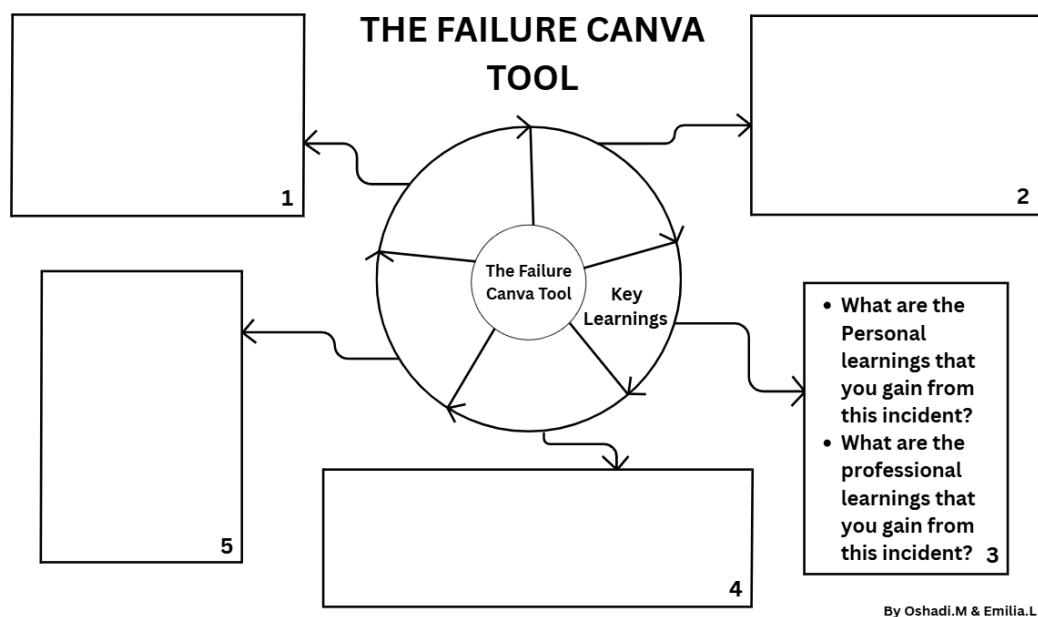


Figure 16. Defining Key Learnings in the Failure Canva Tool

The third phase, "Key Learnings," is inspired from the third question in the Motorola Reflection Method as mentioned previous; it has a dual purpose to help recognize growth on a professional and personal level with two divided questions, "What were your personal learnings from this experience?" and "What were your professional learnings from this experience?", converting what was once an error into the opportunity for self-growth and resiliency (See Figure 16).

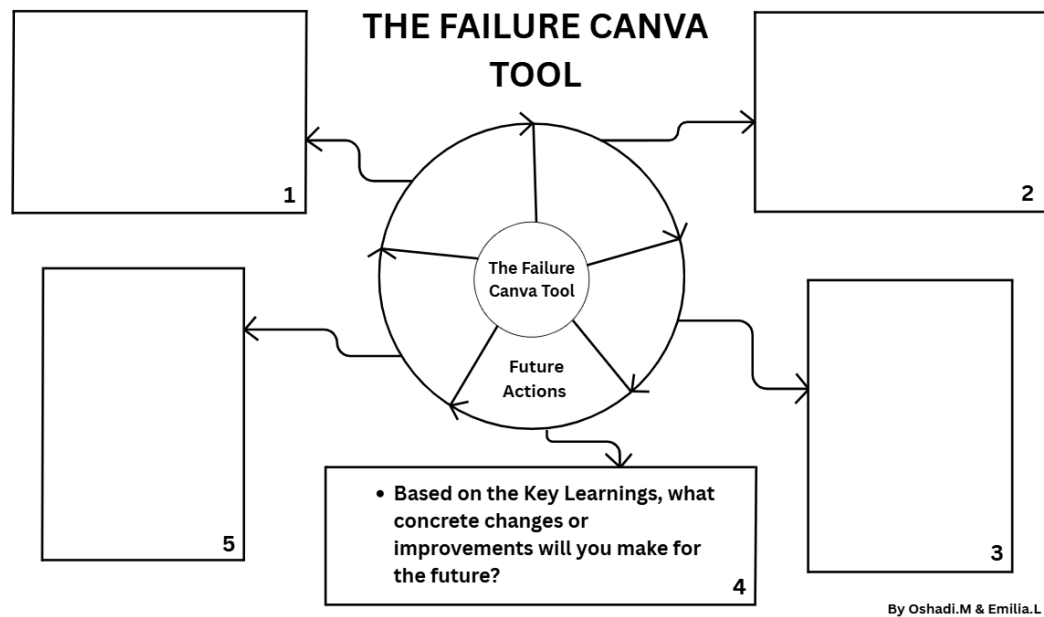


Figure 17. Defining Future Actions in the Failure Canva Tool

The fourth phase, Future Actions. It was developed based on "what am I going to take into practise?" This phase provides the bridge between learning and action by using the following questions: "Based on your Key Learnings, what do you plan to change or improve upon for the future?" and ensures that all learning leads to new actions (See Figure 17).

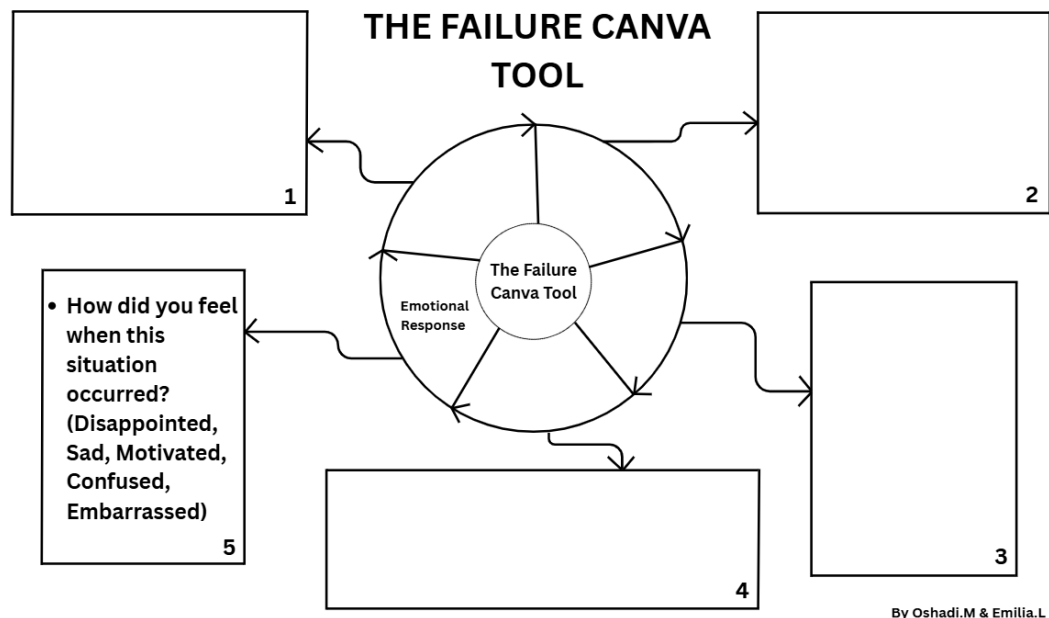


Figure 18. Defining Emotional Response in the Failure Canva Tool

The final, and most unique, phase is Emotional Response. This phase focuses on the emotional impact of failure as it relates to how an individual feels about the experience by asking the question: "How did you feel when this happened? (Sad, Disappointed, Confused, Motivated, Embarrassed)", and allows individuals to become aware of their feelings and begin to process them before they move on (See Figure 18). In total, these five phases with effective questions provide a complete, well-rounded method for transforming failures into continued growth and progress. See Figure 19 for visual layout.

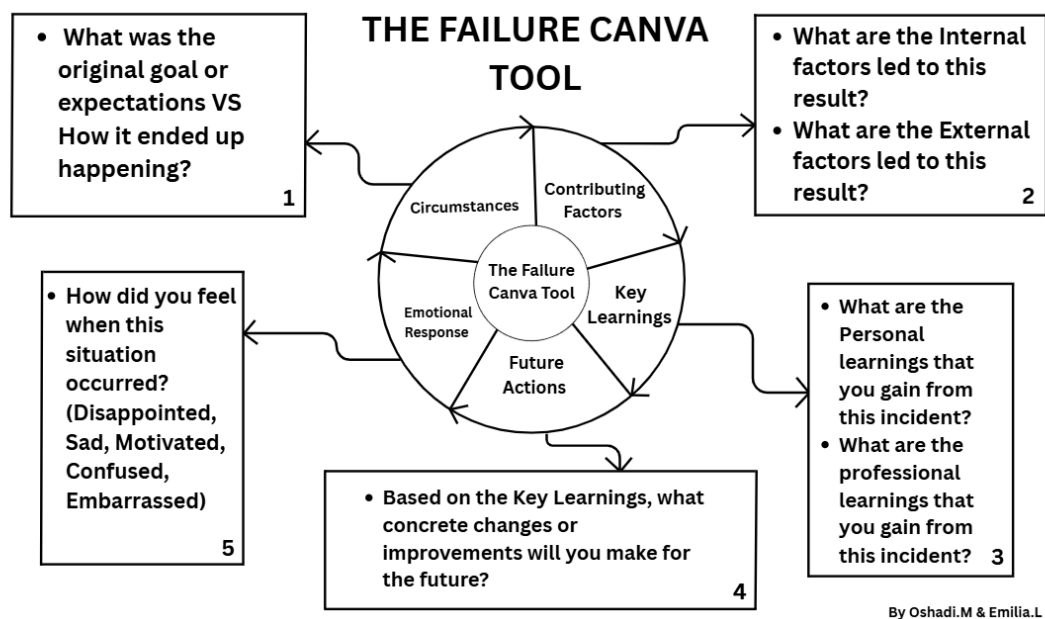


Figure 19. The Failure Canva Tool (own design by Mohottiarachchi & Laakso, 2025) (See appendix 1).

6 QUESTIONS AND STRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT OF THE TOOL

Qualitative interviews were undertaken to develop a foundation for the guiding questions in the five stages of The Failure Canva and to provide a basis for the Canva to be built upon "real" entrepreneurial experiences rather than merely theoretical concepts. Although the framework for the stages and guiding questions for the Canva was based on established theories and frameworks (See Figure 19), it was important to confirm whether or not the stages and guiding questions would have value in reality, and that they would reflect the cognitive, emotional, and strategic processes involved in experiencing failure by entrepreneurs.

Research related to experiential learning has shown that only when theory can be directly associated with real life will an experiential model or tool be successful. This is due to the fact that the application of theory in the real world allows for the opportunity to learn from experience and apply knowledge (Kolb, 1984). Similarly, research related to applied entrepreneurship has also emphasized the importance of validating tools designed to aid founders in their entrepreneurial journey in real-world work environments to determine the usability, reliability, and relevance of such tools (Cope, 2011; Rae, 2006).

Therefore, the interviews with startup provided an opportunity to validate whether or not the Canva reflected the emotional, cognitive, and strategic processes entrepreneurs undergo during the process of failing. Furthermore, their descriptions of how they reacted emotionally, coped, and practiced reflection assisted in refining the wording and focus of the guiding questions for each stage of the Canva to ensure the Canva would be user-friendly, culturally sensitive, motivating, and consistent with the realities of entrepreneurial culture in Finland. As a result of developing the Canva based on a combination of theoretical foundations and real-world validation, the Canva is both academically grounded and practically relevant.

The qualitative interview approach was chosen for this section of the thesis. Qualitative research is about getting close to people's real experiences and understanding their thoughts, feelings, and perspectives in depth. Instead of using numbers, it looks at stories, observations, and conversations to explore *how* and

why something happens. Methods like interviews or observations help researchers notice emotions, personal interpretations, and the kinds of messy, real-life processes that numbers alone cannot explain (Creswell, 2013). Because it offers this kind of rich, contextual insight, qualitative research is especially valuable when developing or testing tools that must make sense in real working life and reflect how people actually behave in practice (Patton, 2015).

Qualitative interview approach allows researchers access to the subjective and contextual aspects of human experience (Denzin and Lincoln, 2018), which is especially useful in understanding sensitive topics such as failure and emotional resilience. The Failure Canva is based on emotional awareness, reflection, and dialogue, all of which require an in-depth understanding of the individual experience. It was necessary to use semi-structured interviews to gain narrative data that could lead to the development of meaningful and user-friendly questions.

Interviews were held with four startup founders or co-founders. All participants were entrepreneurs based in Finland and from varied industries, including digital and mobile applications, food and service businesses, clothing, and beauty and wellness. The criteria for inclusion consisted of selecting founders who had personally been involved in some form of business or project failure and who would consent to speaking openly about their experiences.

Interviews were held from September/2025 to October/2025, in face-to-face and online settings, depending on participant access. (See Appendix 2.) Interviews took on a semi-structured format, with each session lasting about one to two hours. This enabled participants to tell personal stories but covered the same areas consistent to all interviews and discussions. The conversations were audio-recorded with the participants' consent, and detailed notes were taken to support data analysis. (See interview questions on Appendix 3).

6.1 The interview takeaways

After conducting the interviews with startup founders, the authors made transcripts out of the audio recordings and from those, three main insights emerged

that guided the restructuring of the Failure Canva tool and the refinement of several guiding questions. The following sections describe these key changes in detail.

6.1.1 Shifting the starting point: Emotions before analysis

Emotional knowledge and awareness precede factual knowledge and understanding of failure; thus, the emotional experiences associated with failure are just as important as the rational analysis of those failures. The study's findings support previous research that suggests that emotional knowledge is central to the failure learning process, as unprocessed emotion may prevent an individual from cognitively interpreting the failure and hinder their ability to recover (Shepherd, 2003). Two interviewees emphasise this argument by commenting as below,

“Deal firstly with an emotion because that traps the person to get stuck in that... And if he is able to release... the emotional feelings in failing, then it can channel to... strategic planning after” (Food industry Interviewee, personal communication, 2025).

“If something doesn’t make sense to you, then you can be emotionally like, *oh, what the hell happened? Everything is awful.*

But when you understand... your emotions are connected to that” (Digital and mobile applications industry interviewee, personal communication, 2025).

“If you understand your traumas and your emotions connected to the trauma, then you can cope with them.” (Digital and mobile applications industry interviewee, personal communication, 2025).

By considering those interviewees comments and Based upon the theory mentioned before by (Shepherd, 2003), the revised Failure Canvas has placed an emphasis on emotional reflection at the beginning of the failure learning process. The tool provides an opportunity for the entrepreneur to reflect on their feelings in an emotionally safe space prior to their analysing their failure.

Entrepreneurial learning literature emphasizes that acknowledging feelings such as frustration, disappointment and confusion are all important components of reflective thinking and self-awareness (Cope, 2011). Thus, by requiring entrepreneurs to reflect on their emotional state initially, the tool promotes an open and non-judgmental attitude toward their experience, ultimately allowing them to achieve greater depth of learning.

Once the entrepreneur moves through the analytical phases of Circumstances, Contributing Factors, Key Learning, and Future Actions, the tool will then return to emotional reflection one last time. This final emotional reflection stage can enable entrepreneurs to assess changes in their emotional state over the course of the process. Research has identified that emotional recovery the transition from experiencing negative emotions to accepting, feeling relieved, or being motivated is a critical element of an individual's resilience and post-failure growth (Bonanno, 2004). Therefore, the use of emotional reflection at the close of the tool supports entrepreneurs in achieving emotional equilibrium and synthesizing both emotional and analytical knowledge necessary for a complete comprehension of their failure and its transformation into a learning experience (Kolb, 1984).

6.1.2 Redefining contributing factors

Another key finding from the interviews was the section on contributing factors of the study. One of the founders interviewed, who is in the field of clothing sector, explained that one of the reasons for failure in their project was largely due to the Covid-19 pandemic. He explained the situation as below,

“When the pandemic hit, we didn’t really have the expertise... many things were complicated... There are hundreds of decisions you need to make... You cannot control everything.” (Clothing industry interviewee, personal communication, 2025).

This fact highlighted that not all contributing factors are within the control of the entrepreneur. In response to this, The Failure Canva now divides contributing factors into two categories:

1. Within your control
2. Beyond your control

This is an important distinction for entrepreneurs to direct their energy toward what they can control while accepting the external things that cannot be changed. Research on entrepreneurial decision-making shows that founders with a strong internal locus of control focus their efforts on controllable actions, while recognizing that many external forces lie outside their influence (Mensah, 2021). External factors are things not in your control, such as global factors (e.g., pandemics), drastic changes in customer understanding or behaviour, or economic external shocks. According to the article from (Statista, n.d.) the pandemic has made a huge impact for the global startup scene which visualized more in figure 20 below.

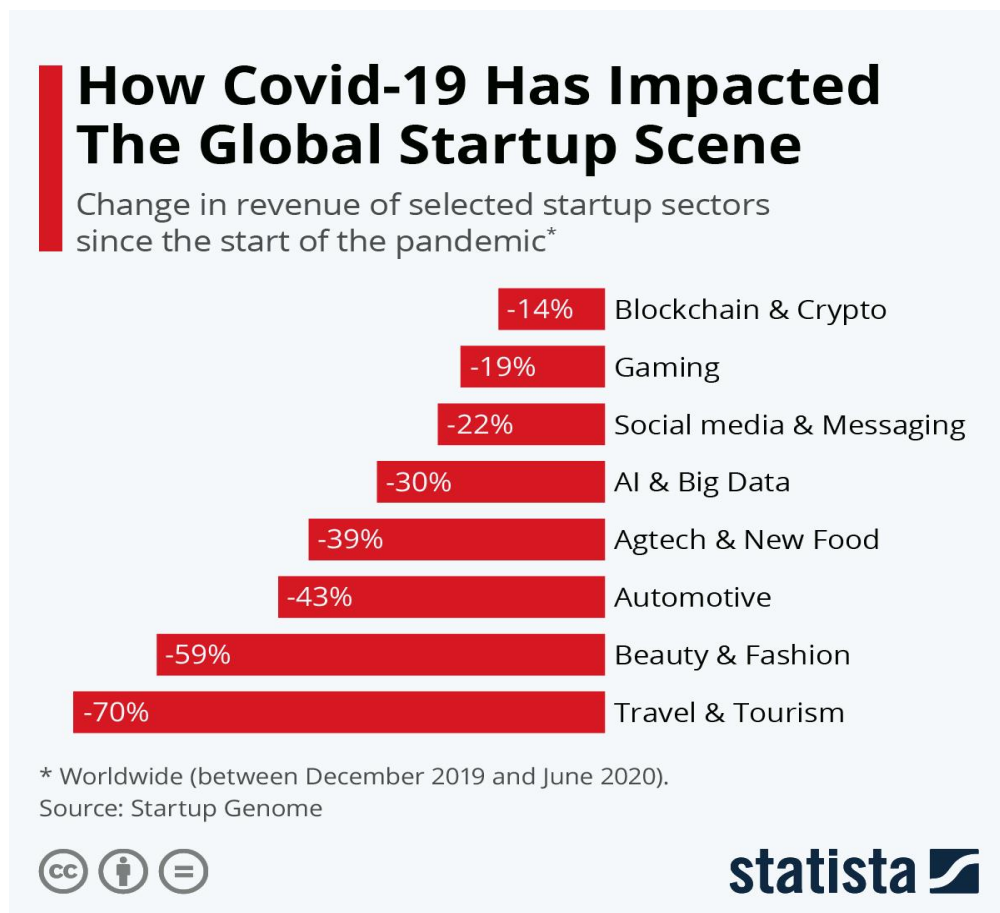


Figure 20. How COVID-19 has impacted the global startup scene

Source: Statista (2020), based on Startup Genome data.

Figure 20 shows that all startups were performing poorly throughout the period of December 2019 to June 2020. The data also shows some startups have more negative results compared to another, but commonly what can be seen is that all had negative results, therefore, no startup was successful in that time frame.

Studies further highlight that macro-environmental shifts, such as sudden market disruptions, regulation changes, or global crises, affect entrepreneurs regardless of their skills or decision-making quality (Tetteh, 2024). In cases of this nature, the optimal thing to do is to accept and acknowledge the situation and let it go. This gives understanding to the fact that not all difficulties are based on poor decision-making or lack of skills.

On the other hand, things that are under one's control, such as leadership style, communication, time management, and product design, provide excellent opportunities to learn. By studying these things, the entrepreneur can see how their own actions contributed to the results. The best way to analyse these things is to acknowledge them, accept them, and learn from them. This encourages a sense of responsibility on the part of the entrepreneur and prepares them for the next stage, key learnings which offer even deeper insights (Amankwah-Amoah et al., 2021).

6.1.3 Expanding key learnings

The interviews also led to the refinement of the Key Learnings section. In the earlier version of The Failure Canva Tool, the leading question was framed as: *“What personal and professional lessons did you gain from this experience?”*

However, the interviews revealed that even when outcomes were negative, entrepreneurs still discovered valuable experiences and moments of success within failure. An interviewee described it as below,

“All of those, they make you a little bit stronger if you're capable of dealing with them... all of the major ones, especially the bigger ones, have led into an action and those actions have been incremental to getting to a certain point of entrepreneurship” (Clothing industry interviewee, personal communication, 2025).

Research also shows that entrepreneurial failure often produces meaningful learning outcomes, economic, social, emotional, and cognitive, even when the venture itself is not successful (Lattacher, 2020). To capture this more balanced perspective, an additional reflective question was introduced:

“What went well, even though the outcome was not successful?”

This question helps entrepreneurs to embrace a compassionate and constructive mindset, which recognizes strengths and progress made during the process, even when the final result did not meet expectations. It helps transform failure into a source of growth rather than feeling discouraged.

6.2 User manual for The Failure Canva Tool

Although the primary reason for conducting the qualitative interviews was to generate guiding questions for the segments in the Failure Canva and ultimately the overall structure of the tool, the interview results have also shown that it would be necessary to create a user manual. The user manual will serve as a reference or handbook for helping entrepreneurs and teams to realize greater value through their use of The Failure Canva. It will include detailed instructions for all steps involved with each section (Circumstances, Contributing Factors, Key Learnings, Future Actions, and Emotional Response) so that users can reflect appropriately and effectively on each area. Structured guidance of this kind supports deeper learning, as reflection becomes more meaningful when users are led through clear stages of analysis and action (Kolb, 1984).

To meet the purpose of the Failure Canva Tool as an educational learning resource, the user manual will do two things: it will describe what each stage is intended to accomplish, and it will lead the user through the complete reflective process. The User Manual will support users in understanding the findings from their reflections. The user manual will address the combination of emotional and analytical elements of reflection by providing insight into how to achieve the proper balance between emotional awareness and strategic application. This aligns with experiential learning theory, which highlights that structured reflection enhances both emotional processing and future action planning (Kolb, 1984). The user manual will provide insight into how flexible the tool is; the tool can be used as an individual reflection experience, or it can be applied in workshops as a means of facilitating an exchange of ideas related to open discussion of experiences with failure.

The User Manual will include additional visual elements (e.g., Colors, shapes, symbols) in addition to its written sections, especially in the Emotional Response

section, which will enable users to express emotions visually as an alternative to expressing them verbally. Therefore, the Emotional stage of the Failure Canva will have no examples of the emotions/expressions to be shown in the tool. The User Manual will also show users that using both visual expressions and written reflections about their experiences can be used to increase self-awareness and to use failures as opportunities for growth, development and building resilience. (See Appendix 4 for the user manual).

6.3 The modified version of The Failure Canva Tool

The final version of the Failure Canva Tool is based on both theoretical knowledge and design principles as well as the qualitative data collected from entrepreneur interviews. The combination of these provided the basis for the development of a revised structure to both provide greater emotional connection and greater analytical insight. A continuous circular design remains consistent with the design of the prior version and the five stages of Emotional Response, Circumstances, Contributing Factors, Key Learnings and Future Actions are connected using simple arrows to visually represent the continuity and flow between each stage.

According to 6.1.1 – 6.1.3 there is three significant revisions in the format were made as a result of feedback received during the interviews. The first revision is the emotional response has been moved to be part of both the beginning and end of the reflection process (Section 6.1.1). The second revision includes changes to the Contributing Factors section by separating the contributing factors into two distinct areas - those that are under the entrepreneur's control and those that are outside of the entrepreneur's control (Section 5.1.2). The third revision expanded based on Section 6.1.3 the Key Learnings section with an added reflective question: "Even though the outcome was not successful, what went well?"

Considering all these developments, the final version of the Failure Canva Tool now looks as follows:

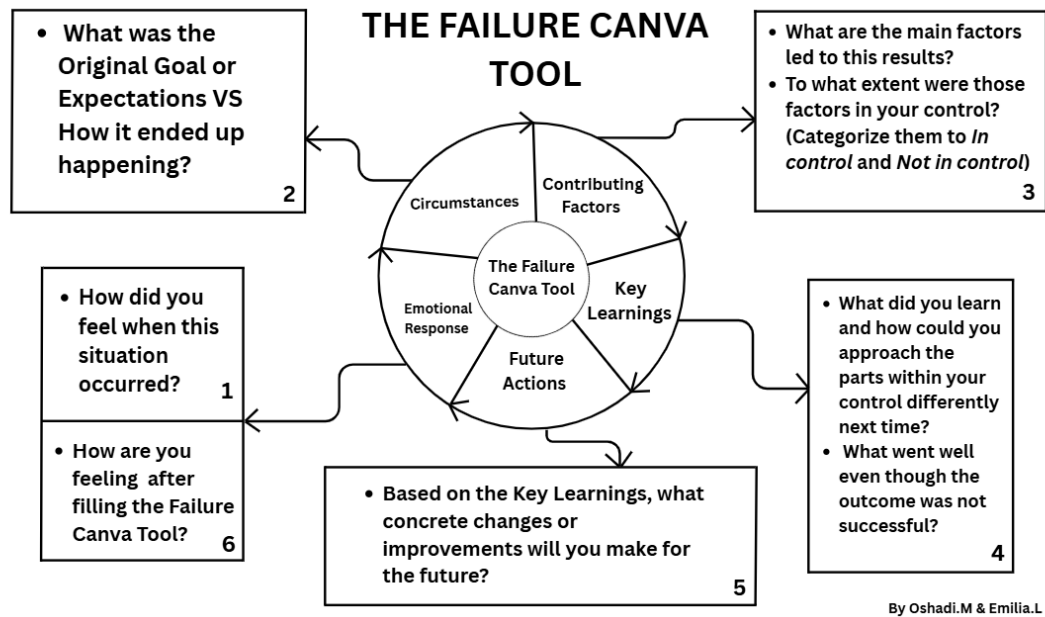


Figure 21. The Modified Failure Canva Tool (own design by Mohottiarachchi & Laakso, 2025) (See Appendix 5).

7 TESTING THE FAILURE CANVA TOOL

The goal of testing the Failure Canvas Tool is to assess how well the principles that are based on research, such as emotional reflection, analytical comprehension, and experiential knowledge that transfer into actual entrepreneurial practice. The testing process will also ensure that The Failure Canvas Tool is user-friendly enough for actual use by entrepreneurs, while providing evidence that the tool can be used by entrepreneurs to convert their failures into learning opportunities and support their growth and development. Kolb's (1984) Experiential Learning Theory emphasizes that learning is most effective when individuals connect reflective observation with concrete experience and continue the cycle through active experimentation, allowing insights to be tested and deepened through action.

In line with this, Shepherd (2003) has stated that entrepreneurs benefit from having tools that enable them to recover emotionally and cognitively at the same time, which leads to an improvement in their ability to learn from failure. This testing can examine will The Failure Canva Tool be a successful bridge between the theoretical and practical aspects of the business world for co-operative organizations, and it can be a tool for both emotional awareness and strategic actions consistent with established learning and entrepreneurship theories.

7.1 The team entrepreneurship program

The degree programme of Tampere University of Applied Sciences (TAMK) is called Proakatemia and is known for its unique model of team learning, which eliminates traditional lecturing by replacing it with self-guided, project-based learning. The students at Proakatemia are not working individually, but as members of cooperative teams, officially registered as a real company where each group is responsible for all aspects of their business, including clients, finances, and leadership. This gives the student an actual first-hand experience with both entrepreneurship and teamwork. (Proakatemia, 2022).

Team members learn within co-operatives through actual entrepreneurial activities (such as completing project assignments for outside clients, working on their own startup ventures, planning/organizing events, and testing new ideas). The

focus is on the practical entrepreneurial skills (e.g., sales, marketing, finance, leadership) and the use of dialogue-based reflective practice. Co-operative models encourage joint responsibility among members, collective learning, and trust, which are consistent with Proakatemia's values of openness, courage, and constant growth and development. As each team member is also a registered member of a co-operative, they have the opportunity to develop hands-on experience in the areas of business management and collaborative leadership, preparing them to graduate and become successful entrepreneurs, innovators and change-makers (Nevalainen, Seikkula-Leino & Salomaa, 2021).

The Failure Canva Tool is tested by five teampreneurs from five different Proakatemia co-operative businesses. Teampreneurs are students who learn entrepreneurship by running a real company as a team, making decisions collectively, selling products/services, and learning through self-organized projects rather than traditional teaching (Hägg & Kurczewska, 2020).

Rather than using personal or company names, each teampreneurs feedback will be marketed as Project A, B, C, D, and E, to keep it anonymous. The teampreneurs were contacted through Microsoft Teams and each agreed to participate and test the tool (see Appendix 6). For the testing process, every participant received a printed version of the tool and was given three days in between week 42 to 43 in 2025 to reflect on their selected failure case. They then evaluated both the circumstances of the failure and the functionality of the tool using the instructions provided (see Appendix 7).

7.2 Feedback from teampreneurs for Failure Canva

Overall, all five teampreneurs provided consistent and useful feedback during the testing phase of the Failure Canva Tool. The feedback was given in a written form through via teams. The written reflections from all five teampreneurs led to several refinements in the design and logic of the Failure Canva Tool. Participants consistently described the tool as clear, structured and emotionally grounding, noting that the numbered flow supported the transition from emotional processing to rational analysis and, finally, to action-oriented learning.

The combination of emotional and analytical dimensions was highlighted as one of the tool's strongest features. As one participant explained, beginning with an emotional response allowed them to "process the feelings and experiences first before shifting towards the learning and next steps of improvement" (Project A, personal communication, 2025). This finding aligns with the theoretical understanding that emotional sense-making is crucial for reflective learning.

The feedback also led to refinements in the order and phrasing of several sections. For instance, one participant expressed that the question "How did you feel when this situation happened?" felt disconnected in its original place and recommended placing it earlier, following a clarification of the original goals or expectations. They noted that this adjustment "creates more connection to the emotional response" and allows the user to understand the experience more holistically (Project C, personal communication, 2025). Similarly, the question "How did it end up happening?" was suggested to be reframed as "What were the outcomes of the project?" to better support clarity and reduce individual perception. These suggestions demonstrate how user feedback can deepen the coherence of reflective tools by improving the alignment between question structure and cognitive flow.

Participants also highlighted the value of further deepening the emotional component of the tool. One teampreneur expressed curiosity about the tool's usefulness *in the moment of failure*, explaining that their own reflection occurred months after the event and therefore lacked the emotional intensity of the original experience. They stated: "I am curious how much it helps me in the heat of the moment right when I am emotionally engaged and triggered" (Project A, personal communication, 2025). This insight reinforces the importance of timing in reflective processes and suggests that immediate engagement may increase emotional authenticity and learning depth (Boud, Keogh & Walker, 1985)

Alongside conceptual suggestions, the participants also offered practical and aesthetic improvements. Many emphasised the potential benefits of a digital version of the tool, such as a fillable PDF, Google Form or Canva template to increase accessibility, ease of use and progress tracking. One teampreneur noted that a digital option would make the tool "simple and visual... easy to follow for

project reflections or personal development sessions,” while also proposing the addition of a follow-up prompt such as “Revisit this after one month” to encourage sustained learning (Project B, personal communication, 2025). Minor design suggestions, such as maintaining equal box sizes for visual coherence, were also raised and will be incorporated in the next iteration of the tool (Project E, personal communication, 2025).

This given feedback showcase that the tool fulfilled its purpose of guiding users through emotional recovery, analytical clarity and constructive learning. Participants described the tool as “a good guide to lay down the failure” (Project E, personal communication, 2025), showing that it resonates with the reflective needs of early-stage entrepreneurs. At the same time, the reflections highlighted opportunities to enhance emotional depth, improve the sequencing of questions, and expand digital accessibility. These insights confirm the tool’s practical value while providing a roadmap for its continued development into a widely applicable framework for supporting entrepreneurial resilience and growth.

8 CONCLUSION

As the final product of both practical development and reflective learning, to understand the experiences, processing and learning from failure of entrepreneurs; The results generated in the time available indicate that the project has generally met these objectives and have generated additional knowledge that exceeded the initial expectations. The development, revision and testing of the Failure Canva Tool clearly illustrated that a structure-based reflective model can provide useful support to entrepreneurs in examining both the cognitive and emotional aspects of failure, which corresponds with Kolb's (1984) Experiential Learning Theory and the inter-relationship of concrete experience, reflective observation and active experimentation.

The participants reported that the use of the tool assisted in articulating emotions, that are typically left unaddressed, and thus reinforced Shepherd et al.'s (2011) argument that emotional recovery is a requirement to learn from failure. Furthermore, the participants' reflections provided evidence of Cope's (2011) assertion that emotionally intense entrepreneurial experiences present opportunities for extensive learning if they are examined through a reflective lens. Consequently, this thesis provided further confirmation of the authors' belief that failure is not a terminal destination, but rather a normal and ubiquitous component of entrepreneurship, that when viewed through a reflective approach, can produce entrepreneurial resilience, growth, and renewed motivation.

Additionally, the project had many identifiable limitations, which need to be recognized. A primary limitation of the project was the four-month timeline of data collection, and therefore, the number of revisions of the tool. While significant effort was taken to include a broader array of entrepreneurs, the authors were only able to secure four external founders due to the busy nature of early-stage startup founders, which is a common constraint in entrepreneurial research (Cope, 2003).

Therefore, the modification of the Canva was heavily dependent on Proakatemia teampreneurs, thereby limiting the variety of the validation sample. If more time

were available, the tool could have been tested across a larger number of industries and entrepreneurial environments, and therefore, would have provided additional insight and enhanced generalizability. Additionally, the time constraints prevented the completion of a completely digital version of the tool, although previous research indicated that easily accessible, easy-to-use, and effective reflective tools increase user engagement and facilitate long-term learning (Boud, Keogh & Walker, 1985).

By reflecting on the whole process, the authors have realized the thesis process by itself became a learning experience through failure, reflection, and improvement, mirroring the subject matter of the thesis. Balancing academic research with developing a practical tool demanded flexibility, collaboration, and problem solving under pressure. Thus, the authors experienced what Kolb (1984) described as experiential learning in action: testing ideas, receiving feedback, revising approaches and continually iterating. Through this process, the authors expanded their knowledge of how reflection assists in developing emotional resilience and personal growth, and therefore, reinforced Cope's (2011) assertion that entrepreneurial learning is often transformative and emotionally taxing.

There are a number of potential avenues for future development of the Failure Canva. Developing a digital and interactive version of the tool will increase access to the tool and enable users to follow their reflection over time. Conducting the tool in wider startup environments such as Tribe Tampere, local incubators, or early-stage founders across multiple industries will enhance the relevance of the tool and enable additional iterative refinement. Incorporating quantifiable measures such as scales assessing emotional resilience or learning progress may also provide a basis for additional research and add to the analytical utility of the tool.

In summary, this thesis repositions failure as part of a constructive, cyclical process of learning, resilience, and innovation, rather than simply a negative consequence. The Failure Canva Tool helps to create a link between theory and practice by enabling entrepreneurs to have a structured method to interpret their ex-

periences and to perceive failure as a meaningful stimulus for growth, a perspective supported by both experiential learning theory (Kolb, 1984), and contemporary research on entrepreneurial failure (Shepherd et al., 2011; Cope, 2011).

Although the research was limited in terms of scope and duration, it highlighted the importance of emotional awareness, and ongoing reflection for entrepreneurs navigating ambiguity. These findings could provide value for future entrepreneurs, educators, and startup communities as they navigate the inevitabilities of entrepreneurial life through continued learning, adaptation, and growth.

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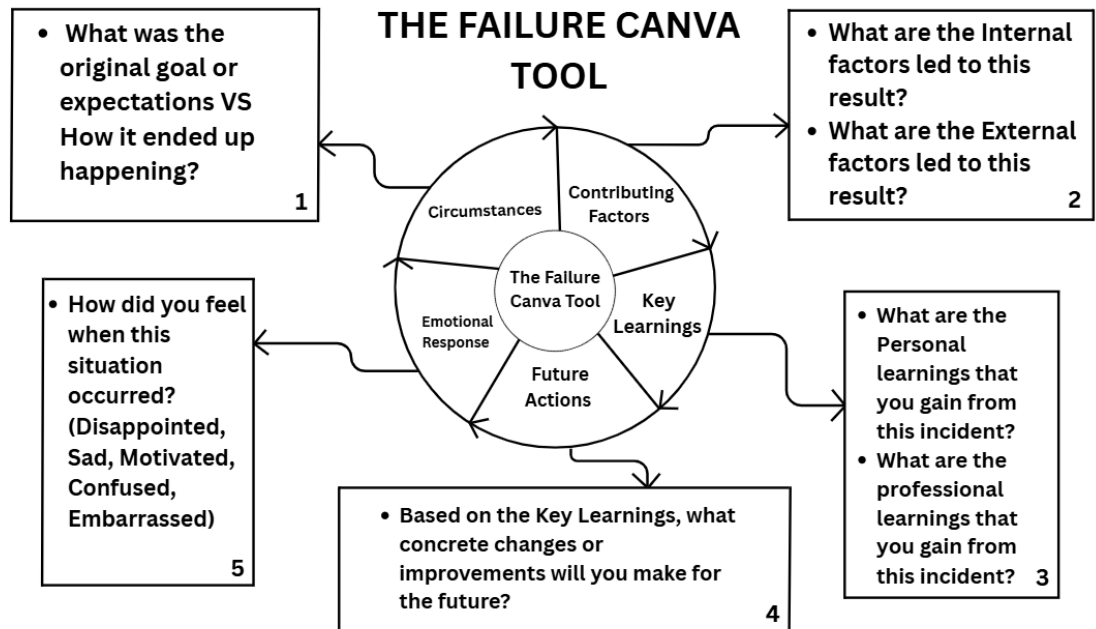
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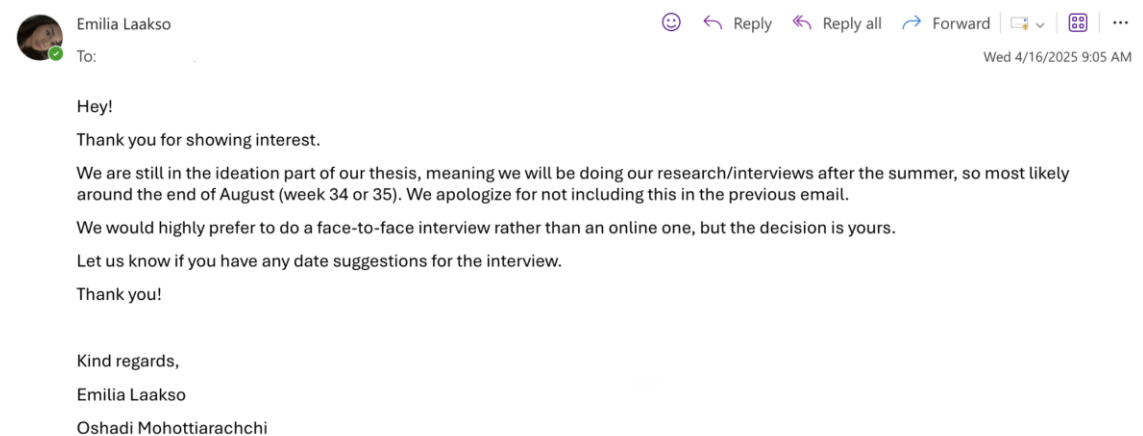
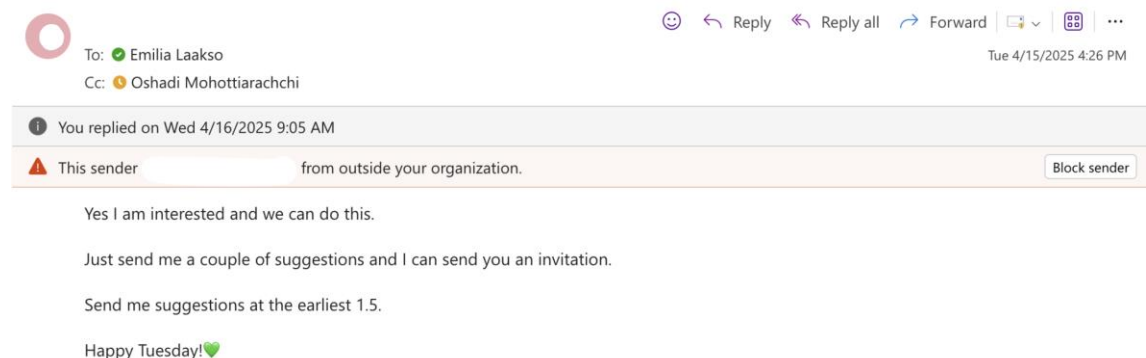
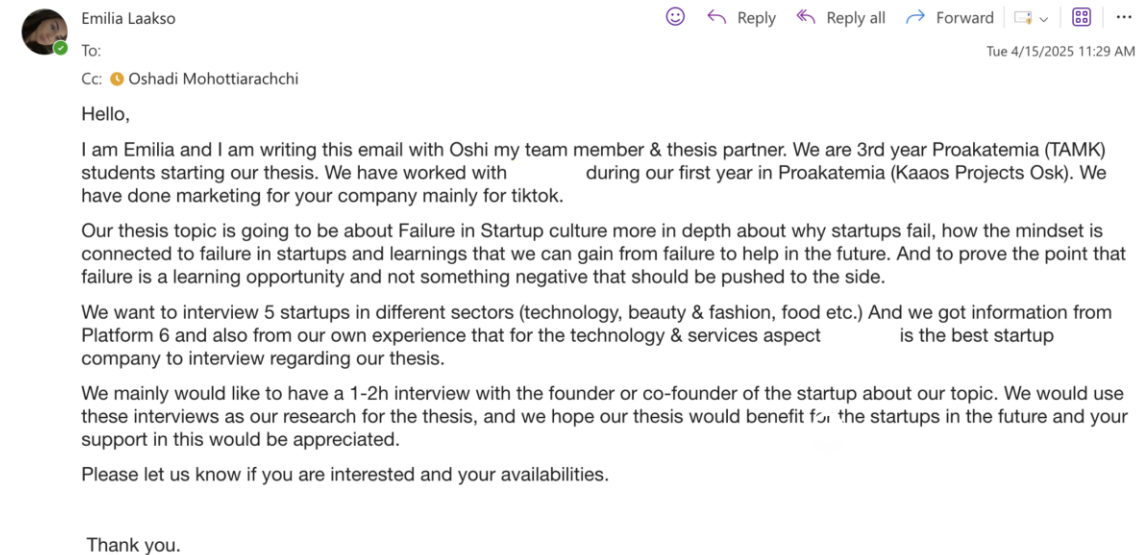
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APPENDICES

Appendix 1. The Failure Canva Tool



Appendix 2. Email sending for the startup interview participants



Appendix 3. Interview questions

Interview questions

Circumstance & Context of Failure

- Can you describe a specific situation in your startup where you felt you had failed (product, service, team, or customer side)?
- What was happening around your business at that time in the market, among your competitors, or inside your team?
- Looking back, do you think this failure was avoidable, or was it inevitable on the journey of building your business?

Contributing Factors

- What internal factors (team dynamics, decision-making, funding, skills) do you think most influenced that failure?
- Was there external pressure (customers, market conditions, regulation, cultural perceptions) that made the situation more difficult?
- If you had more resources at the time (financial, emotional, or network support), do you think the outcome would have been different?

Emotional Response

- What emotions did you feel at the time of failure (fear, shame, relief, disappointment, motivation)?
- Did these emotions affect your decision-making in the following weeks/months?
- How did you personally cope with these feelings, did you talk with someone, keep them inside, or use them as motivation?
- In Finland, failure often carries stigma. Did you feel judged by others (investors, family, society), or was the pressure more internal?

Mindset and Learning

- How has failure changed the way you view yourself as an entrepreneur?
- Did you find any positive meaning in the failure later on, something that helped you grow?
- If you compare yourself before and after experiencing failure, how has your mindset about risk, resilience, and learning shifted?

Future Orientation

- After failure, what concrete steps did you take to recover. (adapting, redesigning your product, or seeking new markets?)
- How do you now prepare yourself and your team for possible failures?
- If failure happened again tomorrow, what would you do differently?

Cultural & Social (Finland-specific)

- Do you feel that Finnish culture makes it harder or easier to talk openly about failure?
- Have you ever avoided sharing your struggles because of how you thought people would react?
- How do you think society, investors, or even your customers in Finland interpret “failure” compared to other countries you know?

Reflections (for the Failure Canva tool)

- When you think of your biggest failure, which part was most difficult: understanding *why* it happened, managing your emotions, or deciding the next step?
- Would you find value in using a structured tool like the Failure Canva to reflect on failure? If yes, how?
- What would make the failure Canva tool most useful to you and your team (simplicity, emotional reflection, or strategy planning?)

Appendix 4. The user manual for The Failure Canva Tool

User Manual for The Failure Canva Tool

Background about The Failure Canva Tool

The **Failure Canva Tool** is designed to help entrepreneurs, students, and teams reflect on and learn from failure through a structured and emotionally supportive process. The purpose of this manual is to guide users step-by-step through each segment of the tool so that they can complete it smoothly and meaningfully. The Canva combines both **emotional reflection** and **analytical learning**, allowing you to process your experiences, understand what went wrong, and transform insights into future growth. This manual helps you navigate each stage with ease, creativity, and honesty—ensuring that failure becomes not an endpoint, but a source of understanding, motivation, and progress.

Stage 1: Emotional Response (Starting Point)

Begin by reflecting on **how you felt when the failure occurred**. This first stage create space for you to express your emotions freely before analyzing the situation.

You can express your emotions in any form that feels natural to you:

- Draw faces or shapes that represent your feelings.
- Use **colors** to reflect your emotions (e.g., red for frustration, blue for calm, yellow for hope).
- Write down words, quotes, or short sentences describing your emotions.
- Combine drawing and writing, be creative, and let your emotions flow naturally.

This stage is meant to help you acknowledge your emotional state honestly and without judgment. Recognizing how you felt sets the foundation for clear reflection later on.

Stage 2: Circumstances

Here, you describe **what happened** in factual terms. Divide this section into two parts:

1. **Original Goal or Expectation** – What was your original plan, goal, or desired outcome?
2. **How It Ended Up Happening** – What was the actual result or situation?

Visual Tip:

Draw two boxes or columns side by side:

Original Goal or Expectation	How It Ended Up Happening

- This visual layout helps you clearly see the gap between what was expected and what occurred
- This stage provides the factual context and allows you to view the event objectively, helping you understand the situation without emotional bias.

Stage 3: Contributing Factors

Now, analyze **what led to this result**. Write down the main internal and external factors that influence the outcome.

Then, categorize them into two columns:

In My/Our Control	Not in My/Our Control

This distinction helps you identify where to focus your energy and what to let go of.

- Factors **in your control** (e.g., time management, communication, decision-making) you can **Recognize, accept** them and **learn** from them using the next stage
- Factors **not in your control** (e.g., economic shifts, illness, weather, global pandemics) you can **Recognize, accept** and **let them go**.

By doing this, you can focus on growth instead of guilt, and move forward with a sense of clarity and balance.

Stage 4: Key Learnings

Based on your previous stage, now reflect on **what you have learned** from this experience.

Ask yourself:

- How could I approach the parts within my control differently next time?
- What did I learn from this experience both personally and professionally?
- What went well, even though the outcome was not as expected?

This stage helps you embrace both the successes and lessons within failure. Remember, even a disappointing outcome can reveal progress, strength, or valuable insight. This reflection turns your experience into knowledge that contributes to your personal and entrepreneurial growth.

Stage 5: Future Actions

In this stage, transform your key learnings into **concrete actions** for the future. Write down what changes, improvements, or new strategies you will implement next time. Consider:

- What will I do differently in similar situations?
- How can I apply what I learned to upcoming projects?
- What specific steps will help me improve?

This stage ensures that your reflection leads to real progress, turning awareness into action, and helping you grow as a resilient entrepreneur or team member.

Stage 6: Emotional Response (Final Reflection)

Return to the emotional dimension once more. Reflect on **how you feel now** after completing the Failure Canva. Compare your current emotions to your initial ones:

- How have your feelings changed?
- Do you feel more at peace, confident, or motivated?
- What emotional progress can you recognize now?

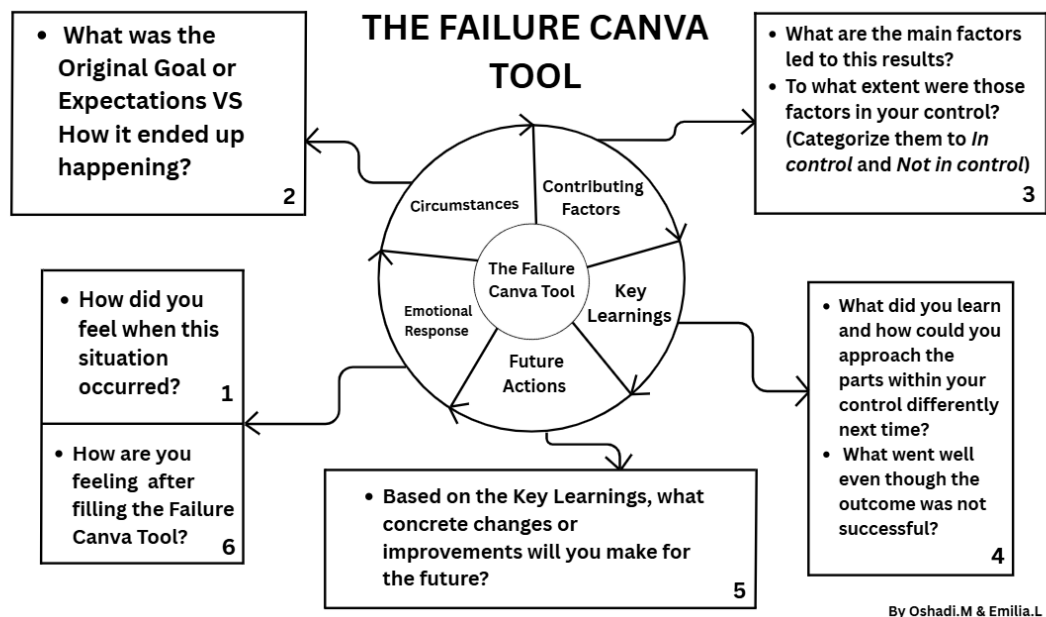
You can again use colors, drawings, or words to represent your emotions. This comparison helps you see your **emotional growth** and understand how reflection has helped you process the failure more constructively.

At last,

By following each stage of the Failure Canva Tool, you will move through a full cycle of **understanding, learning, and renewal**. The circular design represents that every failure can become a new beginning when approached with honesty and reflection. Be

creative, take your time, and remember; this tool is not about judgment, but about transformation. Each time you use it, you build resilience, awareness, and confidence to turn challenges into opportunities for growth.

Appendix 5. The modified Failure Canva Tool



Appendix 6. Message sent for tool validation participant

Hey [redacted] We are creating a tool for our thesis, and it's for reflecting on any failures that have happened in any of your projects. We would like to know if you would be interested in testing the tool. We will print the tool on paper so you could fill it out and give you a user manual to help you fill it. Let me know if you would be interested in testing our "The Failure Canva Tool".

Hi,
That sounds interesting. Yes I would love to test the tool 🙌

Great thanks for the quick reply 😊 We will give you the printed version and manual tomorrow and we can talk more about this. Around what time will you be in Proakatemia tomorrow?

Appendix 7. Introduction for the tool testing

Instructions for Participants

1. Choose a Real Failure Experience

- Select a real project, business idea, or team experience that did not go as planned.
- Situation should be meaningful and involve lessons learned or emotions that stood out during or after the experience.

2. Use the Failure Canva Tool Independently

- **Three days** to complete the reflection.
- Use the tool to move through all five stages:
 1. **Emotional Response** – Express initial emotions connected to the failure (drawings, words, or colors).
 2. **Circumstances** – Describe the original goal or expectation VS what actually happened.
 3. **Contributing Factors** – Identify causes that led to the result.
Divide them into:
 - Factors within your control
 - Factors not in your control
 4. **Key Learnings** – Write down insights gained and note what went well despite the outcome.
 5. **Future Actions** – Define what could be done differently in the future and how it can be applied to future projects.
 6. **Final Emotional Reflection** – Revisit your emotions after completing the tool. Note how your feelings changed compared to the beginning.

3. Reflection Guidelines

- Be honest and open in your reflection.
- Use colors, symbols, or drawings to represent emotions if desired; creativity is encouraged.
- No right or wrong answers exist. Reflect authentically.

4. Evaluation and Feedback

- After you have filled out the tool, please answer these:
 - Was the tool easy to use?
 - Which part was most helpful or insightful?
 - What could be improved in the design or questions?
 - How did you feel before and after using the tool?

